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# Two-loop $gg \to AA$ amplitudes near threshold and the double parton scattering singularity

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Abstract: The two-loop amplitudes for pseudoscalar pair production in gluon fusion, $gg \to AA$, with each pseudoscalar emitted from its own effective gluon vertex, are known in closed form, but large cancellations near threshold obscure their analytic structure. We expand the IR-finite amplitudes in the pseudoscalar velocity $\beta_A$ through $\beta_A^6$ at fixed scattering angle. All inverse powers of $\beta_A$ and the odd powers through $\beta_A^5$ cancel, and at leading power the angular dependence enters only through $\ln(2p_T/m_A)$. We identify this logarithm with the double parton scattering (DPS) singularity: with the overall constant fixed at threshold, the factorisation formula of Gaunt and Stirling reproduces the velocity dependence of its one-loop coefficient in the forward limit exactly, and a one-loop $gg \to HH$ analysis confirms the corresponding CP-even helicity sum. At two loops the equal-helicity amplitude grows as $\ln^3(2p_T/m_A)$, and the ratio of its leading two- and one-loop logarithms agrees with that in planar $\mathcal{N} = 4$ super Yang–Mills theory, while the opposite-helicity amplitude, which has no one-loop DPS logarithm, grows as $\ln^2(2p_T/m_A)$. In the finite virtual correction, relative to the squared tree amplitude, the highest logarithm at order $\alpha_s^2$ is $-\frac{7}{64}\alpha_s^2 N_c^2 \ln^2(2p_T/m_A)$. For $\beta_A \leq 0.2$ the series reproduce the unexpanded amplitudes with relative errors of at most $6.77 \times 10^{-5}$ at the tested points; they provide this two-loop contribution to the hard function for soft-gluon resummation of the pair invariant-mass distribution near $m_{AA} = 2m_A$ and are released with code for their numerical evaluation.

Keywords: Scattering Amplitudes, Higher-Order Perturbative Calculations, Higgs Production

## Contents


**1 Introduction** **2**

**2 Amplitudes and conventions** **6**
- 2.1 Theoretical framework 6
- 2.2 Kinematics 6
- 2.3 Tensor decomposition and helicity amplitudes 7
- 2.4 Finite remainders and normalisation 8
- 2.5 Perturbative order 9
- 2.6 Finite top quark mass effects 9

**3 Threshold expansion** **10**
- 3.1 Construction 11
- 3.2 Endpoint constants and cancellations 11
- 3.3 Accuracy 13

**4 Leading power and the double parton scattering singularity** **16**
- 4.1 Leading power 16
- 4.2 One loop 18
- 4.3 The double parton scattering singularity 19
- 4.4 Two loops 22

**5 Consequences for the cross section** **26**
- 5.1 Leading order 26
- 5.2 Finite virtual corrections 26
- 5.3 Use in higher order calculations 30

**6 Conclusions** **30**

**A Endpoint constants** **32**

**B Normalisation of the released remainders** **33**

**C Flavour decomposition** **34**

**D Evaluation time and released data** **35**

## 1 Introduction

Precision tests of the Standard Model (SM) and searches for new particles at the Large Hadron Collider (LHC) require theoretical predictions for production rates and differential cross sections. QCD radiative corrections in gluon fusion processes can be sizeable, and calculations beyond leading order (LO) are needed to assess their effect on the predicted rates and distributions [1]. Loop amplitudes enter the virtual contributions to these corrections. They can develop singularities at special kinematic configurations even when the corresponding tree amplitudes are regular. The location and strength of these singularities matter for numerical evaluation and for the behaviour of differential cross sections [2–5]. An expansion about such a configuration allows the singular terms to be studied explicitly, together with the regular terms needed for a quantitative prediction.

A relevant example is neutral Higgs boson pair production in two-Higgs-doublet models (2HDM). We consider pseudoscalar pair production in the region of 2HDM parameter space where gluon fusion through top quark loops dominates, so that loop amplitudes enter already at LO [1, 6, 7]. For pseudoscalar pairs, $gg \to AA$, the next-to-leading order (NLO) QCD corrections were first computed in the limit of a heavy top quark [8], later matched to parton showers [9], and subsequently obtained with the full dependence on the top quark mass [1]. NLO QCD corrections in the heavy top quark limit have also been computed for Higgs pair production with CP-violating couplings [10]. In the benchmark considered in [1], the full NLO cross section for $AA$ lies about 5% below the Born-improved heavy top quark approximation at LHC energies, compared with about 12% for $hH$. For this benchmark, the comparison supports using the heavy top quark limit (HTL) as a starting point for higher orders, with the exact mass dependence retained at LO. The two-loop finite remainders in this limit, that is, the amplitudes after subtraction of their infrared poles [11], were obtained in [12] for the class of diagrams studied in this paper (Type II, defined below). For SM Higgs pairs, NLO QCD corrections are known with full top quark mass dependence [13–15], corrections in the HTL are known to N$^3$LO [16–18], and the top-Yukawa and light-quark-induced electroweak corrections have been computed with full top quark mass dependence [19]. The status of these higher-order corrections to SM Higgs pair production, and the resulting recommendations for the total cross section and the pair invariant mass distribution, are summarised in Ref. [20]. The same effective gluon interactions also contribute to the production of axion-like particle pairs, and non-resonant $gg \to aa$ production has been studied for its expected sensitivity to their interactions at the LHC [21].

In the limit of a heavy top quark, a pseudoscalar field $\Phi^A(x)$ couples to gluons and light quarks through the effective Lagrangian [22]

$$\mathcal{L}^A_{\text{eff}} = \Phi^A(x) \left[ -\frac{1}{8} C_G \, O_G(x) - \frac{1}{2} C_J \, O_J(x) \right], \tag{1.1}$$

with the gluonic and light quark operators

$$O_G(x) = G^{a\mu\nu} \tilde{G}^a_{\mu\nu} = \epsilon_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma} G^{a\mu\nu} G^{a\rho\sigma}, \tag{1.2}$$

$$G^{a\mu\nu} = \partial^\mu G^{a\nu} - \partial^\nu G^{a\mu} + g_s f^{abc} G^\mu_b G^\nu_c, \tag{1.3}$$

where $f^{abc}$ are the structure constants of SU($N_c$), with $N_c = 3$ in QCD, and $\epsilon_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}$ is the Levi-Civita tensor. The light quark operator is the divergence of the flavour singlet axial vector current,

$$O_J(x) = \partial_\mu \left(\bar{\psi}\gamma^\mu\gamma^5\psi\right) . \tag{1.4}$$

By the Adler–Bardeen theorem [23, 24], $C_G$ receives no QCD corrections beyond one loop, whereas $C_J$ starts at second order in the strong coupling $a_s \equiv g_s^2/16\pi^2 = \alpha_s/4\pi$. The Wilson coefficients are

$$C_G\left(a_s\right) = -a_s 2^{\frac{5}{4}} G_F^{\frac{1}{2}} \cot\beta\,, \tag{1.5}$$

$$C_J\left(a_s\right) = -\left[a_s C_F\left(\frac{3}{2} - 3\ln\frac{\mu_R^2}{m_t^2}\right) + a_s^2 C_J^{(2)} + ...\right] C_G\,, \tag{1.6}$$

where $G_F$ is the Fermi constant, $m_t$ the top quark mass and $\tan\beta$ the ratio of the vacuum expectation values of the two Higgs doublets, in a CP-conserving 2HDM; this angle is unrelated to the velocity

$$\beta_A = \sqrt{1 - 4m_A^2/\hat{s}} \tag{1.7}$$

of the pseudoscalars in the partonic centre of mass frame, at fixed scattering angle. $C_A = N_c$ and $C_F = (N_c^2 - 1)/(2N_c)$ are the quadratic Casimirs of the adjoint and fundamental representations, respectively. $\mu_R$ is the scale at which $a_s$ is renormalised. The conventions are those of Ref. [12]. Operator mixing, ultraviolet renormalisation and the treatment of $\gamma_5$ [25] follow the original calculation in Ref. [12]; the same effective theory underlies inclusive pseudoscalar production at NNLO [26].

We consider the dominant gluon fusion subprocess

$$g(p_1) + g(p_2) \to A(p_3) + A(p_4), \tag{1.8}$$

with $p_1^2 = p_2^2 = 0$ for the gluons and $p_3^2 = p_4^2 = m_A^2$ for the pseudoscalars. The amplitude for $gg \to AA$ separates into two classes [12]. Type I contains a single effective gluonic insertion, producing the pseudoscalar pair through a contact interaction or an intermediate CP-even scalar. In Type II, each pseudoscalar is emitted from its own vertex and the two vertices are connected by gluon exchange in the $t$ or $u$ channel (Fig. 1a). In the full theory, the Type II tree diagrams correspond to two top quark triangles joined by a gluon, the one-particle reducible contributions of Refs. [1, 8]; for Higgs pairs the corresponding class was computed at two loops [17]. The two-loop Type II finite remainders for $gg \to AA$ were obtained in closed form in Ref. [12]. They contain polylogarithms of weight up to four, among them $\mathrm{Li}_{2,2}$, and inverse powers of the Gram determinant $tu - m_A^4$, which vanishes at the pair threshold. The expressions occupy about 204 MB, and large cancellations between their terms make them hard to evaluate close to threshold.

There are two reasons to study this challenging threshold region. The first is phenomenological. In the NLO predictions of Ref. [1], for $m_A = 134.7$ GeV the invariant mass distribution of the pair is larger at $m_{AA} = 300$ GeV, about 30 GeV above threshold, than at 400 GeV, illustrating the relevance of the lower invariant mass region. Threshold resummation of this distribution requires at each $m_{AA}$ a hard function obtained from the infrared

(IR) finite virtual amplitude [27–31], and the two-loop Type II remainders expanded here supply their contribution to it. The point $m_{AA} = 300$ GeV itself corresponds to $\beta_A \approx 0.44$ and lies outside the recommended range of the present series, $0 < \beta_A \leq 0.2$ at the tested angles, corresponding to $m_{AA} \lesssim 1.02 \times 2m_A$. The threshold of the resummation is also a different limit, that of soft radiation at fixed $m_{AA}$, whereas the expansion here is about $m_{AA} \to 2m_A$ (Sec. 5.3). The forward-limit tests of Sec. 4.4 are separate from both: they examine selected logarithmic coefficients of the unexpanded amplitude at larger velocities and do not extend the validated range of the series.

The second concerns the analytic structure of loop amplitudes. When the transverse momentum $p_T$ of the final state particles vanishes, a one-loop amplitude with massless internal lines can have a Landau singularity [32] in which each incoming parton splits into two collinear partons that then take part in two separate $2 \to 1$ scatterings. For four-jet production, the one-loop contribution in which both incident partons split is enhanced only logarithmically when the transverse momenta of the two jet pairs balance [2, 33]. This double parton scattering (DPS) singularity is at most logarithmic in $p_T$ for SM amplitudes; in the processes examined in Ref. [3], it occurs only when the incoming state has $J_z = 0$. A factorised formula for its coefficient was also derived [3]. The corresponding singularity of six-gluon amplitudes in planar $\mathcal{N} = 4$ super Yang–Mills theory has been studied to high loop order [4, 5]. However, it has not been examined beyond one loop in QCD at the level of amplitudes for a $2 \to 2$ process with a colour singlet final state; NLO corrections to the underlying splitting mechanism are known [34] for double parton distributions [35, 36]. The availability of a complete multiloop amplitude does not by itself make the behaviour of a particular Landau region explicit: cancellations between kinematic prefactors and logarithms can obscure the singular limit. The threshold expansion below isolates this structure in an explicit two-loop QCD amplitude. The Type II amplitude for $gg \to AA$ contains diagrams with this topology: each incoming gluon can split into two gluons, which fuse pairwise into the two pseudoscalars at the effective vertices (Fig. 1b). At threshold, $p_T \to 0$ at every scattering angle, so a threshold expansion probes this configuration directly.

In hadronic collisions, a configuration in which a parton from each proton splits into two can enter both the single and double parton scattering calculations. The overlap must therefore be removed to avoid counting the same contribution twice [2, 34, 37–43]. DPS also receives a contribution in which only one of the two parton pairs arises from a perturbative splitting, while the other proton supplies two partons without such a splitting [2, 33, 37, 38, 44]. This contribution has been studied for Higgs boson pairs [45]. DPS has also been observed in same-sign $W$ pair production at the LHC [46, 47]; estimates of its effective cross section that include the contribution with one perturbative splitting are given in Ref. [38]. The overlap between single and double parton scattering has been re-examined using two-loop splitting kernels [48]. The amplitude-level singularity studied here is not itself a double parton distribution or a hadronic DPS cross section. It is the corresponding singular region of the single parton scattering loop amplitude, and therefore provides complementary information on the perturbative splitting configuration that also enters the overlap between single and double parton scattering.

In this paper, we expand the two-loop Type II finite remainders of Ref. [12] in the

velocity $\beta_A$ through $\beta_A^6$. The main results are the following:

1. After the constants that arise in the expansion are expressed in a basis of eight transcendental constants, all inverse powers of $\beta_A$ and the odd powers through $\beta_A^5$ cancel, and every coefficient is even in $\cos\theta$, as required by Bose symmetry. At leading power, the angle enters only through the logarithm of the transverse momentum $p_T$ of the pseudoscalars.

2. This logarithm is the DPS singularity. At one loop its coefficient follows the factorised formula of Ref. [3] for gluon splitting and the opposite signs of the amplitudes for $g^+g^+ \to A$ and $g^-g^- \to A$: with the overall constant fixed at threshold, it reproduces the velocity dependence of the exact one-loop coefficient in the forward limit. A one-loop calculation of $gg \to HH$ confirms the corresponding helicity sum for a CP-even coupling.

3. At two loops the $J_z = 0$ amplitude, with equal gluon helicities, grows as $\ln^3(2p_T/m_A)$. The ratio of its leading two and one-loop logarithms agrees with the corresponding leading-logarithmic ratio in planar $\mathcal{N} = 4$ super Yang–Mills theory [4, 5]. Forward-limit fits support the coefficient relations in Eq. (4.16) at the tested velocities in $0.05 \leq \beta_A \leq 0.7$. The $|J_z| = 2$ amplitude has no DPS logarithm at one loop but develops a $\ln^2(2p_T/m_A)$ term at two loops. Fits at the tested velocities in $0.05 \leq \beta_A \leq 0.5$ support a real coefficient equal to $-4N_c$ times the one-loop forward amplitude. The origin of this double logarithm remains open.

4. At leading power, the one-loop DPS logarithm does not contribute to the finite virtual interference with the tree amplitude because the two are out of phase. At the next order, the cubic logarithm of the two-loop amplitude gives a quadratic logarithm in its interference with the tree amplitude. Combining this interference with the square of the one-loop amplitude gives

$$V_2 \supset -\frac{7}{4}\pi^2 N_c^2 \ln^2\left(\frac{2p_T}{m_A}\right).$$

   Here $V_2$ is the finite virtual coefficient at two-loop order, normalised to the squared Type II tree amplitude, as defined in Eq. (5.2).

We use the common normalisation defined in Sec. 2.4 and checked in App. B. At the tested points with $0 < \beta_A \leq 0.2$, the series reproduce the two complete unexpanded remainders with relative errors of at most $6.77\times10^{-5}$. The series and code for their numerical evaluation are provided with the paper [49].

The paper is organised as follows. Section 2 sets out the conventions, the normalisation of the remainders and the counting of orders. Section 3 summarises the procedure and describes the expansion and its accuracy. Section 4 discusses the leading power terms and their relation to the DPS singularity, and Sec. 5 their consequences for the cross section. The conclusions are in Sec. 6.

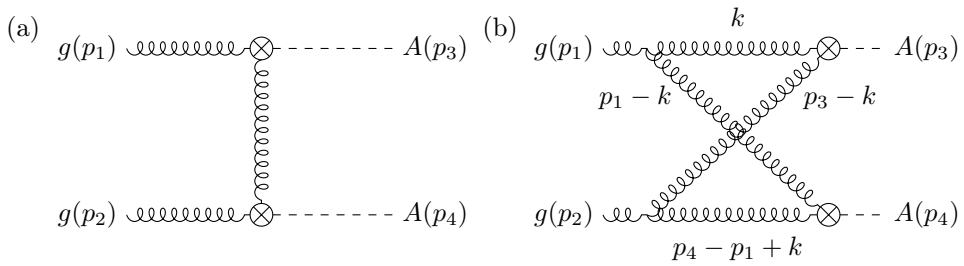



**Figure 1**. (a) Type II tree diagram in the $t$ channel; the $u$-channel diagram is obtained by exchanging the pseudoscalars. The crossed circles are the effective vertices of $O_G$. (b) One-loop Type II diagram with loop momentum $k$. Its double parton scattering singularity lies at $k = xp_1$ and $p_3 - k = (1-x)p_2$, where the four internal gluons are on shell and collinear with the incoming gluons: each incoming gluon splits into two, which fuse pairwise at the effective vertices. This topology is the crossed box of Ref. [3].

## 2 Amplitudes and conventions

### 2.1 Theoretical framework

To study the threshold behaviour of $gg \to AA$ through two loops, we use the amplitudes from Ref. [12] with the effective Lagrangian of Eq. (1.1). The labels Type I and Type II follow that reference and distinguish the two classes of diagrams. They are unrelated to the Yukawa types of 2HDMs. Here we consider the contribution with two $O_G$ insertions and omit the superscript II from the amplitudes. Diagrams with one $O_G$ and one $O_J$ insertion first contribute at one loop. Their coefficients are proportional to the $O_G$–$O_G$ tree coefficients, as discussed in Sec. 2.4.

### 2.2 Kinematics

The Mandelstam variables are

$$\hat{s} = (p_1 + p_2)^2, \qquad t = (p_1 - p_3)^2, \qquad u = (p_2 - p_3)^2, \tag{2.1}$$

with $\hat{s} + t + u = 2m_A^2$. Following the conventions of Ref. [12], we use

$$\hat{s} = m_A^2 \frac{(1+v)^2}{v}, \qquad t = -m_A^2 y, \qquad u = -m_A^2 z, \tag{2.2}$$

with $v + v^{-1} = y + z$; $v$ is the variable called $x$ in Ref. [12], renamed here because $x$ denotes a momentum fraction in Sec. 4. With $c = \cos\theta$ in the partonic centre of mass frame,

$$\hat{s} = \frac{4m_A^2}{1-\beta_A^2}, \qquad t, u = m_A^2 - \frac{\hat{s}}{2}(1 \mp \beta_A c), \tag{2.3}$$

Solving Eq. (2.3) for the variables of Eq. (2.2) and taking the branch $0 < v \leq 1$ gives the threshold substitution

$$v = \frac{1-\beta_A}{1+\beta_A}, \qquad y, z = \frac{1+\beta_A^2 \mp 2\beta_A c}{1-\beta_A^2}. \tag{2.4}$$

All three variables tend to one as $\beta_A \to 0^+$ at fixed $c$, and the expansion has to follow this correlated limit. The Gram determinant and the transverse momentum are related by $tu - m_A^4 = \hat{s}\, p_T^2$, with

$$tu - m_A^4 = \frac{4m_A^4\beta_A^2(1-c^2)}{(1-\beta_A^2)^2}, \qquad p_T^2 = \frac{m_A^2\beta_A^2(1-c^2)}{1-\beta_A^2}. \tag{2.5}$$

Both vanish at threshold at every angle, and also at fixed $\beta_A$ when $c \to \pm 1$.

### 2.3 Tensor decomposition and helicity amplitudes

Every Type II diagram carries two effective vertices, so the amplitude is proportional to $C_G^2$ at every order. Extracting this factor, we decompose

$$\mathcal{M}_{ab}^{\mu\nu} = C_G^2\, \delta_{ab}\, (T_1^{\mu\nu}\mathcal{M}_1 + T_2^{\mu\nu}\mathcal{M}_2)\,, \tag{2.6}$$

with

$$T_1^{\mu\nu} = g^{\mu\nu} - \frac{p_1^\nu p_2^\mu}{p_1\cdot p_2}, \tag{2.7}$$

$$T_2^{\mu\nu} = g^{\mu\nu} + \frac{1}{(p_1\cdot p_2)p_T^2}\Big[m_A^2 p_2^\mu p_1^\nu - 2(p_1\cdot p_3)p_2^\mu p_3^\nu - 2(p_2\cdot p_3)p_3^\mu p_1^\nu + 2(p_1\cdot p_2)p_3^\mu p_3^\nu\Big], \tag{2.8}$$

$$p_T^2 = \frac{tu - m_A^4}{\hat{s}}. \tag{2.9}$$

For physical gluon polarisations, $T_1$ contributes only to equal helicities ($J_z = 0$) and $T_2$ only to opposite helicities ($|J_z| = 2$), each with a contraction of unit modulus. Up to helicity-dependent overall phases, which drop out of every squared quantity, the amplitudes for incoming gluon helicities ($\lambda_1\lambda_2$), with the common colour factor $\delta_{ab}$ suppressed, are [50]

$$\mathcal{A}_{\pm\pm} = C_G^2\,\mathcal{M}_1, \qquad \mathcal{A}_{\pm\mp} = C_G^2\,\mathcal{M}_2\, e^{\pm 2i\phi}, \tag{2.10}$$

where $\phi$ is the azimuthal angle of $\vec{p}_3$ about the beam axis. Equal helicities correspond to $J_z = 0$ along the beam and opposite helicities to $J_z = \pm 2$; the phase of $\mathcal{A}_{\pm\mp}$ is fixed by rotations about the beam axis. Summing over the two configurations of each kind and over colour,

$$\sum_{\text{hel,col}} |\mathcal{A}|^2 = 2(N_c^2-1)\, C_G^4\, \left(|\mathcal{M}_1|^2 + |\mathcal{M}_2|^2\right). \tag{2.11}$$

The labels 1 and 2 refer to the tensors of Eq. (2.6), not to the Type I and Type II diagram classes.

At tree level the two Type II diagrams give

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{M}_1^{(0)} &= \frac{i\hat{s}}{2},\\ \mathcal{M}_2^{(0)} &= \frac{im_A^2(v-z)(v^2+1)(vz-1)}{4vz(v^2-vz+1)}\\ &= 2im_A^2\beta_A^2(1-c^2) + \mathcal{O}(\beta_A^4),\end{aligned} \tag{2.12}$$

in the variables of Eq. (2.2). We obtained Eq. (2.12) from the projections of the original calculation and checked it against a direct evaluation of the two Feynman diagrams with the vertex $iC_G\varepsilon_{\mu\alpha\rho\beta}k_1^\mu k_2^\rho\delta^{ab}$ that follows from Eq. (1.1) (App. B). The suppression of $\mathcal{M}_2^{(0)}$ by $\beta_A^2$ is the centrifugal barrier of the $|J_z|=2$ state: two spin-zero particles can carry two units of angular momentum along the beam only orbitally, at a cost of $\beta_A^2$ near threshold.

### 2.4 Finite remainders and normalisation

The coefficients $\mathcal{M}_i$ of Eq. (2.6), from which $C_G^2$ has been factored out, are expanded as

$$\mathcal{M}_i = \mathcal{M}_i^{(0)} + a_s\mathcal{M}_i^{(1)} + a_s^2\mathcal{M}_i^{(2)} + \cdots , \tag{2.13}$$

with $a_s$ renormalised at $\mu_R$. We use dimensional regularisation with $d = 4+\epsilon$, following Ref. [12]. The finite remainders, called the finite part in Ref. [12], are defined by the IR subtraction of Refs. [11, 12],

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{M}^{(1)} &= 2I^{(1)}\mathcal{M}^{(0)} + \mathcal{M}^{(1),\text{fin}},\\ \mathcal{M}^{(2)} &= 4I^{(2)}\mathcal{M}^{(0)} + 2I^{(1)}\mathcal{M}^{(1)} + \mathcal{M}^{(2),\text{fin}}.\end{aligned} \tag{2.14}$$

We use the subtraction operators implemented in the original calculation, including the convention for the $H_g^{(2)}$ term specified in App. B. From here on $\mathcal{M}^{(n)}$ denotes the finite remainder $\mathcal{M}^{(n),\text{fin}}$.

At two loops, we decompose each finite remainder into powers of the number of light quark flavours,

$$\mathcal{M}_i^{(2)} = \mathcal{M}_{i,0}^{(2)} + n_f\,\mathcal{M}_{i,1}^{(2)} + n_f^2\,\mathcal{M}_{i,2}^{(2)}. \tag{2.15}$$

Each $\mathcal{M}_{i,k}^{(2)}$ is finite, but none is the amplitude of a separate process: the term linear in $n_f$, for example, combines the diagrams with a closed quark loop with the terms of the renormalisation and of the infrared subtraction that depend on $n_f$. In the rest of the paper, the complete coefficient means $\mathcal{M}_i^{(2)}$ at $n_f = 5$. Furthermore, the remainders released with Ref. [12] are normalised differently at different orders: the two-loop remainders carry an overall factor 64 relative to the tree and one-loop amplitudes, and the one-loop remainders are those for $\mu_R = 1$ GeV. In the normalisation of Eq. (2.13), the remainders are therefore

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{M}_i^{(1)} &= \mathcal{M}_{i,\text{publ}}^{(1)} + 2\beta_0 \ln\frac{\mu_R^2}{\text{GeV}^2}\,\mathcal{M}_i^{(0)},\\ \mathcal{M}_i^{(2)} &= \frac{1}{64}\,\mathcal{M}_{i,\text{publ}}^{(2)},\end{aligned} \tag{2.16}$$

with $\beta_0 = (11N_c - 2n_f)/3$ and masses in GeV. The first line restores the renormalisation-scale dependence absent from the released one-loop files. The second removes the overall factor 64 from the released two-loop files. Appendix B checks both conversions against the original calculation and the renormalisation group relations. The two-loop rescaling leaves the relative truncation errors unchanged. Restoring the one-loop scale dependence changes the one-loop constant and the finite virtual corrections, but not the coefficient of the DPS logarithm. All comparisons between perturbative orders below use Eq. (2.16).

The one-loop amplitude with one $O_G$ and one $O_J$ insertion enters at $\mathcal{O}(a_s^4)$, the order of the two-loop $O_G$–$O_G$ amplitude, since $C_J = \mathcal{O}(a_s)\, C_G$. It is proportional to the tree amplitude: in the normalisation of Eqs. (3.6) and (3.7) of Ref. [12],

$$\mathcal{M}_{i,GJ,\mathrm{publ}}^{(1),\mathrm{fin}} = -48\, n_f\, \mathcal{M}_i^{(0)}, \qquad i = 1, 2, \tag{2.17}$$

at every point of the physical phase space. The proportionality is consistent with the axial anomaly, which relates the divergence of the flavour singlet axial current to the gluonic pseudoscalar operator [23, 25, 51]. At $\mathcal{O}(a_s^4)$ the mixed contribution therefore has the kinematic dependence of the tree amplitude and adds no logarithm of $p_T$.

### 2.5 Perturbative order

In Eq. (2.13), the superscript $(n)$ counts loops of gluons and light quarks in the effective theory; in a two-Higgs-doublet model the top quark loops are contained in the Wilson coefficients. The perturbative order of a contribution to the cross section also depends on the powers of $a_s$ in the Wilson coefficients.

Since $C_G \propto a_s$, the Type II tree, one-loop and two-loop contributions to the full amplitude are of order $a_s^2$, $a_s^3$ and $a_s^4$, respectively. In a 2HDM, the leading amplitude is of Type I and starts at $\mathcal{O}(a_s)$, giving a LO cross section of order $a_s^2$. Interference between the leading Type I amplitude and the Type II tree amplitude contributes at order $a_s^3$, that is at NLO. This is the one-particle reducible contribution to the virtual corrections in Refs. [1, 8]. The Type II two-loop amplitude first enters through its interference with the leading Type I amplitude at order $a_s^5$, or N$^3$LO. The same counting applies to the corresponding class of amplitudes for Higgs pairs [17]. The mixed $O_G$–$O_J$ contribution of Sec. 2.4, of the same order $a_s^4$ as the two-loop $O_G$–$O_G$ amplitude, also contributes at this N$^3$LO.

When no Type I amplitude is present, the Type II tree amplitude instead gives the LO cross section. This is the case for an axion-like particle whose only relevant interaction is its coupling to gluons through $G\tilde{G}$. The one-loop and two-loop terms in Eq. (2.13) then provide virtual contributions at NLO and NNLO, respectively. The present results therefore supply the $O_G$–$O_G$ part of the two-loop virtual correction at NNLO for this process. A contact interaction of dimension six containing two pseudoscalars and two gluon fields would introduce an additional Type I amplitude, as in Ref. [21].

### 2.6 Finite top quark mass effects

The threshold expansion and the heavy top quark approximation involve different limits. Taking $\beta_A \to 0$ places the pair invariant mass close to $2m_A$, but imposes no restriction on $m_A/m_t$. Finite top quark mass effects must therefore be assessed separately when $A$ is the pseudoscalar of a 2HDM, at values of $\tan\beta$ for which the top quark loop dominates. No heavy top quark approximation is involved when the coupling to $G\tilde{G}$ is specified directly as an effective interaction, as in the axion-like particle case above. For single pseudoscalar production with jets, the heavy top quark effective theory and its form-factor-improved version have been compared with the full top and bottom quark mass dependence in Ref. [52]; the on-shell form factor used there is the factor $\tau_A f(\tau_A)$ of Eq. (2.19) below.

To estimate the size of the finite top quark mass effects, we start from the Type II tree amplitude, whose dependence on the top quark mass is known [1]. In the full theory each of the two triangles of a given channel couples a pseudoscalar to one on-shell gluon and one virtual gluon and is described by the same form factor $I_2(\tau_A, \lambda)$, with heavy top quark limit $I_2^\infty$. Each triangle therefore contributes a factor $I_2(\tau_A, \lambda)/I_2^\infty$ relative to the effective vertex, and the contribution of the channel is multiplied by

$$\left[\frac{I_2(\tau_A, \lambda)}{I_2^\infty}\right]^2, \quad \tau_A = \frac{4m_t^2}{m_A^2}, \quad \lambda = \frac{4m_t^2}{t} \quad \text{or} \quad \frac{4m_t^2}{u}. \tag{2.18}$$

Here $I_2$ is the loop function that also appears in $A \to Z\gamma$ [1], with $\lambda$ evaluated at the virtuality of the exchanged gluon in the $t$ and $u$ channel, respectively. At the pair threshold, $t = u = -m_A^2$, so both channels have the same factor: 1.006, 1.013 and 1.022 for $m_A = 125$, 150 and 170 GeV, respectively, with $m_t = 172.5$ GeV. These differ from unity by at most about 2.2%.

For the loop corrections, a partial estimate can be made for the one-loop DPS logarithm. Its coefficient involves the amplitudes for $gg \to A$ with both gluons on shell, as discussed in Sec. 4.3. The relevant triangle form factor is therefore obtained in the limit $\lambda \to \infty$, rather than at the spacelike virtuality of the exchanged gluon in the tree diagrams:

$$\frac{I_2(\tau_A, \infty)}{I_2^\infty} = \tau_A f(\tau_A), \qquad f(\tau) = \arcsin^2\left(\frac{1}{\sqrt{\tau}}\right). \tag{2.19}$$

This form holds for $\tau_A \geq 1$, which includes the masses considered here. If the DPS factorisation applies to the full theory, with the top quark triangles treated as hard subgraphs, the coefficient of the one-loop logarithm is multiplied by $[\tau_A f(\tau_A)]^2$, one factor for each of the two subprocesses $gg \to A$; for these masses, this is also the ratio of the full to the heavy top quark LO cross section for $gg \to A$. This gives 1.096, 1.145 and 1.196 for the same three masses, while the velocity dependence and the helicity selection rule remain unchanged. For these masses, the estimated finite top quark mass effect on the one-loop DPS logarithmic coefficient is about 10–20%, compared with at most 2.2% for the Type II tree amplitude at threshold. The difference arises because the DPS hard subprocesses contain two on-shell gluons, whereas each tree triangle contains a spacelike virtual gluon. These are changes to amplitudes or their logarithmic coefficients, not to the full $AA$ cross section. Neither this estimate nor the comparison of tree amplitudes determines the finite top quark mass corrections to the remaining one-loop terms or to the complete two-loop amplitude.

## 3 Threshold expansion

The calculation has four steps, each checked independently. First, the finite remainders of Ref. [12] are split into their flavour coefficients and brought to the normalisation of Eq. (2.16) (App. B). Second, each flavour coefficient is expanded about $\beta_A = 0$ at fixed angle, through $\beta_A^4$ and, independently, through $\beta_A^6$ (Sec. 3.1). Third, the constants that arise at the endpoints are reduced to a basis of eight transcendental constants, after which, with the numerically identified relations, the inverse and odd powers of $\beta_A$ cancel identically

(Sec. 3.2 and App. A). Fourth, the series are compared with the unexpanded remainders, evaluated in Mathematica at increasing working precision and, at selected points, with an independent Python code (Sec. 3.3). The software and the computing environment are described in App. D.

### 3.1 Construction

The remainders of Ref. [12] are functions of $v$, $y$ and $z$ (Eq. (2.2)). We replace these variables by their expressions in $\beta_A$ and $c$ from Eq. (2.4), and expand each flavour coefficient about $\beta_A = 0$ at fixed $c$,

$$\mathcal{M}^{(2)}_{i,r}(\beta_A, c) = \sum_{n=-4}^{p} \sum_{k} C^{(i,r)}_{nk}\, \beta_A^n \ln^k \beta_A + \mathcal{O}_{\log}(\beta_A^{p+1}), \tag{3.1}$$

with $r = 0, 1, 2$ and $p = 4$ or 6. The coefficients $C^{(i,r)}_{nk}$ depend on $c$, $m_A^2$, $\mu_R^2$ and $N_c$, and $\mathcal{O}_{\log}(\beta_A^n)$ stands for $\beta_A^n$ times a polynomial in $\ln \beta_A$. Inverse powers appear in intermediate steps because the tensor basis and the rational prefactors contain inverse Gram determinants, Eq. (2.5). They must be kept until all contributions at a given power have been combined.

The remainders contain logarithms, classical polylogarithms and the function $\mathrm{Li}_{2,2}$ of weight four [53, 54], whose arguments approach correlated endpoints as $\beta_A \to 0$. We expand the rational prefactors exactly and obtain the expansions of the special functions from differential equations in $\beta_A$, with boundary values at $\beta_A = 0$. These equations have the iterated-integral form familiar from harmonic polylogarithms [55] and from canonical differential equations for Feynman integrals [56]; the map $v = (1-\beta_A)/(1+\beta_A)$ is one of the transformations under which harmonic polylogarithms are closed [55]. The method thus expands the known remainders, not the loop integrals, which could instead be expanded near threshold by the method of regions [57]. Expansions of two-loop gluon fusion amplitudes in kinematic limits are also used to obtain compact representations that are fast to evaluate, for example for small transverse momentum and at high energy [58, 59] and about the top quark pair threshold [60]; the present expansion is about the pair production threshold of the massless remainders. For the dilogarithm, for example, $\mathrm{d}\,\mathrm{Li}_2(v)/\mathrm{d}\beta_A = 2(1-\beta_A^2)^{-1} \ln[2\beta_A/(1+\beta_A)]$ with $\mathrm{Li}_2(1) = \pi^2/6$ gives

$$\begin{aligned}\mathrm{Li}_2(v) = {} & \frac{\pi^2}{6} + 2\beta_A\big[\ln(2\beta_A) - 1\big] - \beta_A^2 \\ & + \beta_A^3\left[\frac{2}{3}\ln(2\beta_A) + \frac{1}{9}\right] - \frac{2}{3}\beta_A^4 + \mathcal{O}\big(\beta_A^5 \ln \beta_A\big)\,.\end{aligned} \tag{3.2}$$

Since the prefactors start at $\beta_A^{-4}$, the special functions have to be expanded four orders beyond the final accuracy. The fourth and sixth order expansions were constructed independently, and all coefficients common to both agree.

### 3.2 Endpoint constants and cancellations

The boundary values at $\beta_A = 0$ involve thirteen nontrivial constants $\mathrm{MB}[p, q, a, w]$, in addition to two elementary values. They are defined in Eq. (A.1) of App. A, with $a, w \in$

$\{-1, \frac{1}{2}, 1\}$. Using the PSLQ algorithm [61] at 110 digits, we identify integer relations expressing these constants in the basis

$$\{\zeta_3,\ \pi^2 \ln 2,\ \ln^3 2,\ \pi^4,\ \pi^2 \ln^2 2,\ \ln^4 2,\ \mathrm{Li}_4(\tfrac{1}{2}),\ \zeta_3 \ln 2\}. \tag{3.3}$$

We use the conventional transcendental-weight assignment: $\ln 2$ and $\pi$ have weight one, while $\zeta_n$ and $\mathrm{Li}_n(1/2)$ have weight $n$; weights add under multiplication. The first three constants in Eq. (3.3) have weight three and the remaining five have weight four. Constants of this type occur in alternating Euler sums [62]. The numerically identified relations are listed in Table 7; the largest residual is $4 \times 10^{-107}$. These relations are identified numerically and have not been proved analytically; the cancellations below are exact once they are used.

After substituting these relations, we use the reflection and Landen identities to express the dilogarithms with arguments $(1-c)/2$, $(c-1)/(c+1)$ and $(c+1)/(c-1)$ in terms of $\mathrm{Li}_2\big((1+c)/2\big)$. With the overall factor $m_A^2$ extracted, the coefficient of each power $\beta_A^n$ is a polynomial in

$$\big\{\ln \beta_A,\ \ln(1 \pm c),\ \mathrm{Li}_2\big(\tfrac{1+c}{2}\big),\ \ln \tfrac{m_A^2}{\mu_R^2}\big\} \cup \{\ln 2,\ \pi,\ \zeta_3,\ \mathrm{Li}_4(\tfrac{1}{2})\}, \tag{3.4}$$

with coefficients rational in $c$ and $N_c$. Treating the listed quantities as algebraically independent, we verify symbolically that

1. the coefficients of $\beta_A^{-4}, \ldots, \beta_A^{-1}$ vanish identically in every flavour coefficient;
2. the coefficients of $\beta_A$, $\beta_A^3$ and $\beta_A^5$ vanish identically, so that through $\beta_A^6$ the expansion is a series in $\beta_A^2$ with logarithms;
3. the 24 coefficients at orders $\beta_A^0$, $\beta_A^2$, $\beta_A^4$ and $\beta_A^6$ across the six flavour components are even in $c$, so that Bose symmetry holds order by order.

The cancellations and the reductions of the constants were confirmed independently in Mathematica.

The cancellations have a simple origin. Exchanging the pseudoscalars exchanges $t$ and $u$, so the remainders depend on the kinematics through invariants that are symmetric under this exchange,

$$\hat{s} = \frac{4m_A^2}{1-\beta_A^2}, \qquad (t-u)^2 = \hat{s}^2 \beta_A^2 c^2, \qquad tu - m_A^4 = \hat{s}\, p_T^2, \tag{3.5}$$

with $p_T^2$ given in Eq. (2.5). The difference $t - u = \hat{s}\beta_A c$, which is odd in $\beta_A$, enters only through its square. Each invariant depends on $\beta_A$ only through $\beta_A^2$ and on $c$ only through $c^2$, so a function analytic in them at threshold is a series in $\beta_A^2$ and even in $c$. Odd or inverse powers of $\beta_A$ would therefore signal non-analytic behaviour at threshold. There is no threshold for a pair of massive internal particles at $\hat{s} = 4m_A^2$, since the loops contain no massive particles, and the colourless final state has no QCD Coulomb singularity. These observations alone do not exclude other Landau singularities: the singularity at $p_T \to 0$ discussed in Sec. 4.3 is one, and at one loop it is logarithmic [2, 3, 33]. The Gram determinant $tu - m_A^4$ vanishes at the same point, but its inverse powers come from

| quantity | inverse powers in construction | leading power | powers of $\mathcal{L}$ |
|---|---|---|---|
| $\mathcal{M}^{(2)}_{1,0}$ | $\beta_A^{-2}$, $\beta_A^{-1}$ | $\beta_A^0$ | $0, 1, 2, 3$ |
| $\mathcal{M}^{(2)}_{1,1}$ | – | $\beta_A^0$ | $0, 1, 2$ |
| $\mathcal{M}^{(2)}_{1,2}$ | – | $\beta_A^0$ | $0$ |
| $\mathcal{M}^{(2)}_{2,0}$ | $\beta_A^{-4}$, $\beta_A^{-3}$, $\beta_A^{-2}$, $\beta_A^{-1}$ | $\beta_A^0$ | $0, 1, 2$ |
| $\mathcal{M}^{(2)}_{2,1}$ | $\beta_A^{-1}$ | $\beta_A^0$ | $0, 1$ |
| $\mathcal{M}^{(2)}_{2,2}$ | – | $\beta_A^2$ | $0$ |

**Table 1**. Leading terms of the threshold expansion of the two-loop Type II remainders. The second column lists the inverse powers with nonzero coefficients in the construction files; they cancel identically after the reductions of Sec. 3.2, as do all odd powers. The last column gives the powers of $\mathcal{L}$, Eq. (4.1), at leading power.

the tensor basis and the rational prefactors; they are not singularities of the amplitude. In the present calculation, the explicit expansion shows that the inverse powers cancel and that the remaining singular behaviour is logarithmic in $p_T$. A remainder of the form $\sum_k a_k \ln^k p_T^2$, with coefficients $a_k$ analytic in the invariants of Eq. (3.5) at threshold, is therefore a series in $\beta_A^2$ with logarithms and has no inverse powers. This accounts for the form of the cancellations found above. At two loops it is not an independent proof, because there the logarithmic nature of the singularity is established only by the calculation itself.

Table 1 lists the leading terms. Since the odd powers vanish, the first omitted term is expected to be $\mathcal{O}_{\log}(\beta_A^{p+2})$ rather than the $\mathcal{O}_{\log}(\beta_A^{p+1})$ of Eq. (3.1). The truncation errors should therefore scale as $\beta_A^6$ for $p = 4$ and as $\beta_A^8$ for $p = 6$, up to logarithmic factors.

The coefficients of $n_f^2$ in Eq. (2.15) have the simplest threshold behaviour:

$$\mathcal{M}^{(2)}_{1,2}(\beta_A, c) = K_{n_f} + \mathcal{O}(\beta_A^2), \tag{3.6}$$

$$\mathcal{M}^{(2)}_{2,2}(\beta_A, c) = \beta_A^2(1 - c^2)K_{n_f} + \mathcal{O}(\beta_A^4), \tag{3.7}$$

where $K_{n_f}$ is the angle-independent threshold value of $\mathcal{M}^{(2)}_{1,2}$, with the overall factor $n_f^2$ excluded. The $n_f^2$ component is the only flavour component that follows the tree-level pattern $\mathcal{M}_2 \propto \beta_A^2(1 - c^2)$ of Eq. (2.12), with the same ratio to the tree amplitude in both tensor structures. The complete expressions through $\beta_A^6$ are released as Wolfram Language files (App. D).

### 3.3 Accuracy

We compared the series with the unexpanded remainders on the grid in Table 2, which contains 9 values of $\beta_A$ between $10^{-3}$ and $3/10$, 5 scattering angles and 3 combinations of mass, renormalisation scale and number of colours. At each of the 135 points, the comparison included the six flavour coefficients and the two complete coefficients, giving 1080 comparisons in total. Each unexpanded remainder was evaluated using an adaptive sequence of working precisions: 80, 120, 160, 220 and 300 digits. Evaluation stopped at the

first pair of successive precisions that agreed to a relative difference below $10^{-25}$, with at least 30 significant digits in both. All reference values on the reported validation grid were accepted at the 80/120-digit pair. The parameter set with $N_c \neq 3$ was included to test the colour dependence; all physical results use $N_c = 3$. The relative truncation error is defined as

$$E_i^{(p)} = \frac{\left|\mathcal{M}_i^{[p]} - \mathcal{M}_i\right|}{|\mathcal{M}_i|}, \qquad p = 4, 6, \tag{3.8}$$

where $\mathcal{M}_i$ is the unexpanded remainder and $\mathcal{M}_i^{[p]}$ its series through $\beta_A^p$.

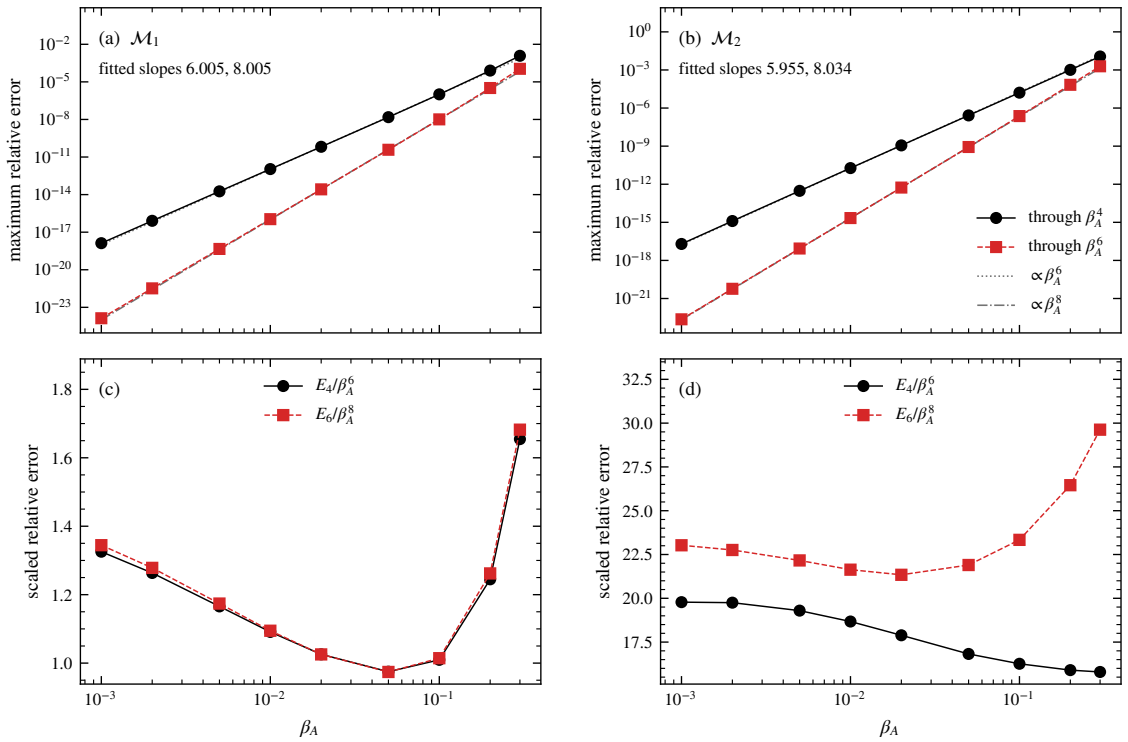



**Figure 2**. Relative truncation errors, Eq. (3.8), of the complete two-loop coefficients at $n_f = 5$: $\mathcal{M}_1$ (left) and $\mathcal{M}_2$ (right). Upper panels: maximum over the angles and parameter sets of Table 2 for the series through $\beta_A^4$ (circles) and through $\beta_A^6$ (squares), with lines proportional to $\beta_A^6$ and $\beta_A^8$. Lower panels: the same maxima divided by $\beta_A^6$ and $\beta_A^8$.

Figure 2 shows these errors for the complete coefficients at $n_f = 5$. The slopes of the curves, discussed below, test the scaling $\beta_A^{p+2}$ expected from the cancellation of the odd powers. Because each curve is a maximum over the points of Table 2, a change of the point that gives the maximum as $\beta_A$ varies would distort these slopes. For the series through $\beta_A^6$ this does not occur: for both coefficients and at every velocity the maximum comes from the same point, $c = 0$ with $m_A = 150$ GeV, $\mu_R = 75$ GeV and $N_c = 4$, so the curves follow the error of a single point. For the series through $\beta_A^4$ the same holds for $\mathcal{M}_1$, while for $\mathcal{M}_2$ the maximum alternates between two parameter sets at $|c|$ =2/3. The maximum is also representative of the grid: at each velocity and for both orders the errors at all other points lie within a factor of eight of it.

| quantity | values |
|---|---|
| $\beta_A$ | 1/1000, 1/500, 1/200, 1/100, 1/50, 1/20, 1/10, 1/5, 3/10 |
| $c$ | $-2/3$, $-1/3$, 0, 1/3, 2/3 |
| $(m_A/\mathrm{GeV},\ \mu_R/\mathrm{GeV},\ N_c)$ | $(125, 125, 3)$, $(125, 250, 3)$, $(150, 75, 4)$ |

**Table 2**. Validation grid. At each point the six flavour coefficients and the two complete $n_f = 5$ coefficients are compared.

| | $\mathcal{M}_1$ through | | $\mathcal{M}_2$ through | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| $\beta_A$ | $\beta_A^4$ | $\beta_A^6$ | $\beta_A^4$ | $\beta_A^6$ |
| 0.01 | $1.09 \times 10^{-12}$ | $1.09 \times 10^{-16}$ | $1.87 \times 10^{-11}$ | $2.16 \times 10^{-15}$ |
| 0.05 | $1.52 \times 10^{-8}$ | $3.81 \times 10^{-11}$ | $2.63 \times 10^{-7}$ | $8.55 \times 10^{-10}$ |
| 0.10 | $1.01 \times 10^{-6}$ | $1.01 \times 10^{-8}$ | $1.63 \times 10^{-5}$ | $2.33 \times 10^{-7}$ |
| 0.20 | $7.97 \times 10^{-5}$ | $3.23 \times 10^{-6}$ | $1.02 \times 10^{-3}$ | $6.77 \times 10^{-5}$ |
| 0.30 | $1.21 \times 10^{-3}$ | $1.10 \times 10^{-4}$ | $1.15 \times 10^{-2}$ | $1.94 \times 10^{-3}$ |

**Table 3**. Maximum relative errors of the complete Type II coefficients on the validation grid. At each value of $\beta_A$, the maximum is taken over the 5 angles and 3 parameter sets of Table 2.

| | $c$ | $\beta_A = 0.1$ | $\beta_A = 0.2$ | $\beta_A = 0.3$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| $\mathcal{M}_1$ | 0.9 | $6.36 \times 10^{-9}$ | $1.11 \times 10^{-6}$ | $1.78 \times 10^{-5}$ |
| $\mathcal{M}_1$ | 0.99 | $1.06 \times 10^{-8}$ | $2.43 \times 10^{-6}$ | $5.76 \times 10^{-5}$ |
| $\mathcal{M}_1$ | 0.999 | $1.23 \times 10^{-8}$ | $2.96 \times 10^{-6}$ | $7.18 \times 10^{-5}$ |
| $\mathcal{M}_2$ | 0.9 | $1.39 \times 10^{-7}$ | $3.08 \times 10^{-5}$ | $6.68 \times 10^{-4}$ |
| $\mathcal{M}_2$ | 0.99 | $6.68 \times 10^{-8}$ | $1.47 \times 10^{-5}$ | $2.88 \times 10^{-4}$ |
| $\mathcal{M}_2$ | 0.999 | $6.21 \times 10^{-8}$ | $1.65 \times 10^{-5}$ | $3.74 \times 10^{-4}$ |
| $\mathcal{M}_1$ | grid max. | $1.01 \times 10^{-8}$ | $3.23 \times 10^{-6}$ | $1.10 \times 10^{-4}$ |
| $\mathcal{M}_2$ | grid max. | $2.33 \times 10^{-7}$ | $6.77 \times 10^{-5}$ | $1.94 \times 10^{-3}$ |

**Table 4**. Relative truncation errors $E_i^{(6)}$ of the complete $n_f = 5$ coefficients towards the beam, at $m_A = \mu_R = 125\,\mathrm{GeV}$ and $N_c = 3$. The last rows give the largest value on the grid of Table 2. The values at $c = -0.99$ equal those at $-c$.

For the series through $\beta_A^4$, the fitted slopes of the logarithm of the maximum error against $\ln \beta_A$ over the plotted range are 6.005 for $\mathcal{M}_1$ and 5.955 for $\mathcal{M}_2$; for the series through $\beta_A^6$ they are 8.005 and 8.034. The expected values are 6 and 8 (Sec. 3.2), while a surviving odd power would give values close to 5 and 7. The small deviations from 6 and 8 are consistent with the powers of $\ln \beta_A$ and the higher terms omitted from the series.

In the lower panels, exact power behaviour would give horizontal lines. The scaled

errors vary slowly, because both the omitted terms and the remainders that normalise the errors contain powers of $\ln\beta_A$, and over the tested range they change by less than a factor of two. An incorrect coefficient at a retained order would instead make them grow as an inverse power of $\beta_A$ as $\beta_A$ decreases. Towards $\beta_A = 0.3$ the scaled errors of the series through $\beta_A^6$ rise for both coefficients, as the terms beyond the first omitted order begin to contribute.

Table 3 lists the maximum errors at selected velocities. For $\beta_A \leq 0.2$, the series through $\beta_A^6$ reproduces $\mathcal{M}_1$ and $\mathcal{M}_2$ with relative errors of at most $3.23 \times 10^{-6}$ and $6.77 \times 10^{-5}$; at $\beta_A = 0.3$ the errors are $1.10 \times 10^{-4}$ and $1.94 \times 10^{-3}$. Bose symmetry was checked by comparing the values at $c$ and $-c$: they are identical in all stored digits in 432 comparisons of the unexpanded coefficients and 864 of the series. The reference values were computed in Mathematica from the expressions of Ref. [12]. To check their evaluation independently, we wrote a separate Python code with mpmath [63]. It reads the published files with its own parser and computes $\mathrm{Li}_{2,2}$ from its defining double sum, or from a one-dimensional integral representation where the sum converges slowly. At four points covering the three parameter sets, the two complete coefficients agree with the reference values to a relative difference of at most $1.3 \times 10^{-40}$, the precision to which the reference values are stored. The six flavour coefficients, compared at $\beta_A = 1/10$ and $c = 1/3$, agree to $1.6 \times 10^{-40}$. At $c = 0$, where $t = u$, the published expressions have removable singularities and are evaluated as limits.

The expansion is made at fixed angle, but $p_T$ vanishes as $c \to \pm 1$ at fixed $\beta_A$, so the series must also be tested close to the beam axis. We therefore compared it with the unexpanded remainders at $c = 0.9$, 0.99, 0.999 and $-0.99$ for $\beta_A = 0.1$, 0.2 and 0.3. Table 4 gives the relative errors of the series through $\beta_A^6$. All values are below the maximum on the main grid at the same $\beta_A$, except for $\mathcal{M}_1$ at $\beta_A = 0.1$, where the largest value, $1.23 \times 10^{-8}$ at $c = 0.999$, exceeds it by 21%. The series thus remains accurate close to the beam, consistent with its coefficients having no poles at $c = \pm 1$, only logarithms of $1 \pm c$ (Sec. 4.1).

## 4 Leading power and the double parton scattering singularity

### 4.1 Leading power

To determine the leading threshold behaviour of the two-loop remainders, we first collect the terms of order $\beta_A^0$, including all powers of $\ln\beta_A$ that multiply them. The notation $\big|_{\beta_A^0}$ used below denotes this part of the expansion.

In the expanded remainders, the logarithms of $\beta_A$ and of the angular variables appear at leading power in the combination $\ln\beta_A + \frac{1}{2}\ln(1-c^2)$. We therefore introduce

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{L} &= \ln\beta_A + \tfrac{1}{2}\ln(1-c^2) + \ln 2 + \frac{i\pi}{2} \\ &= \tfrac{1}{2}\ln\bigl[-4\beta_A^2(1-c^2)\bigr], \end{aligned} \tag{4.1}$$

where the logarithm of the negative argument is taken on the branch $\ln(-X) = \ln X + i\pi$ for $X > 0$, which is the one followed by the remainders in the physical region.

The meaning of $\mathcal{L}$ follows from Eq. (2.5). Substituting the expressions for $tu - m_A^4$ and $p_T^2$ gives

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{L} &= \tfrac{1}{2}\ln\frac{m_A^4 - tu}{m_A^4} + \ln(1-\beta_A^2) \\ &= \ln\frac{2p_T}{m_A} + \frac{i\pi}{2} + \tfrac{1}{2}\ln(1-\beta_A^2).\end{aligned} \tag{4.2}$$

The last term is of order $\beta_A^2$. Near threshold, $\mathcal{L}$ is therefore the logarithm of the transverse momentum of the pseudoscalars, up to the constant phase $i\pi/2$ and power corrections. Away from threshold the natural variable is $\mathcal{G} = \frac{1}{2}\ln[(m_A^4 - tu)/m_A^4] = \mathcal{L} - \ln(1-\beta_A^2)$, used in Sec. 4.4.

When the leading power terms are rewritten in terms of $\mathcal{L}$, no separate $\ln(1 \pm c)$ or $\mathrm{Li}_2\big((1+c)/2\big)$ remains, and the rational dependence on $c$ cancels. All dependence on the scattering angle is then contained in $\mathcal{L}$, and the coefficients of its powers are independent of $c$. For general $N_c$ and $n_f$,

$$\mathcal{M}_1^{(2)}\big|_{\beta_A^0} = m_A^2 \sum_{k=0}^{3} \widehat{A}_{1k}\, \mathcal{L}^k, \tag{4.3}$$

$$\mathcal{M}_2^{(2)}\big|_{\beta_A^0} = m_A^2 \sum_{k=0}^{2} \widehat{A}_{2k}\, \mathcal{L}^k. \tag{4.4}$$

The highest logarithmic coefficients are

$$\begin{aligned} \widehat{A}_{13} &= -\tfrac{28}{3}\pi N_c^2, & \widehat{A}_{12} &= -\tfrac{14}{3}\pi N_c(11N_c - 2n_f), \\ \widehat{A}_{22} &= -2\pi N_c^2, & \widehat{A}_{21} &= -\tfrac{4}{3}\pi N_c(4N_c - n_f), \end{aligned} \tag{4.5}$$

which do not depend on $\mu_R$, and

$$\widehat{A}_{11} = \frac{\pi N_c}{9}\big(N_c\, a_{\mathrm{A}} - n_f\, a_{\mathrm{F}}\big), \tag{4.6}$$

where

$$\begin{aligned} a_{\mathrm{A}} &= 1454 + 462\ln 2 + 252\ln^2 2 - 42\pi^2 + 693\, i\pi - 693 L_\mu, \\ a_{\mathrm{F}} &= 152 + 84\ln 2 + 126\, i\pi - 126 L_\mu, \end{aligned}$$

and $L_\mu = \ln(m_A^2/\mu_R^2)$. Table 5 gives all coefficients for $N_c = 3$, $n_f = 5$ and $\mu_R = m_A$. At $\beta_A^2$, $\beta_A^4$ and $\beta_A^6$ the same substitution again removes every $\ln(1 \pm c)$ and $\mathrm{Li}_2$; the remaining dependence on the angle is rational, even in $c$ and free of poles at $c = \pm 1$.

The exact one-loop remainders already contain $\mathcal{L}$, since they depend on

$$\begin{aligned} &\ln(y - v) + \ln(z - v) \text{ and} \\ &(y - v)(z - v) = yz - 1 = (tu - m_A^4)/m_A^4 \end{aligned}$$

by Eq. (2.2). The two-loop coefficients have no finite limit as $\beta_A \to 0$; they grow as $\mathcal{L}^3$ and $\mathcal{L}^2$ (Fig. 3).

| | $k$ | exact | Re $\widehat{A}_{ik}$ | Im $\widehat{A}_{ik}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| $\mathcal{M}_1$ | 3 | $-\frac{28}{3}\pi N_c^2$ | $-2.63894 \times 10^2$ | 0 |
| $\mathcal{M}_1$ | 2 | $-\frac{14}{3}\pi N_c(11N_c - 2n_f)$ | $-1.01159 \times 10^3$ | 0 |
| $\mathcal{M}_1$ | 1 | Eq. (4.6) | $3.55129 \times 10^3$ | $4.76702 \times 10^3$ |
| $\mathcal{M}_1$ | 0 | – | $-3.98215 \times 10^2$ | $-4.00569 \times 10^3$ |
| $\mathcal{M}_2$ | 2 | $-2\pi N_c^2$ | $-5.65487 \times 10^1$ | 0 |
| $\mathcal{M}_2$ | 1 | $-\frac{4}{3}\pi N_c(4N_c - n_f)$ | $-8.79646 \times 10^1$ | 0 |
| $\mathcal{M}_2$ | 0 | – | $3.12007 \times 10^2$ | $3.40501 \times 10^2$ |

**Table 5**. Coefficients of the leading power term, $\mathcal{M}_i|_{\beta_A^0} = m_A^2 \sum_k \widehat{A}_{ik}\, \mathcal{L}^k$, with $\mathcal{L}$ of Eq. (4.1). They do not depend on the scattering angle. Exact forms for $\mu_R = m_A$ and general $N_c$, $n_f$; numerical values for $N_c = 3$, $n_f = 5$, $\mu_R = m_A$.

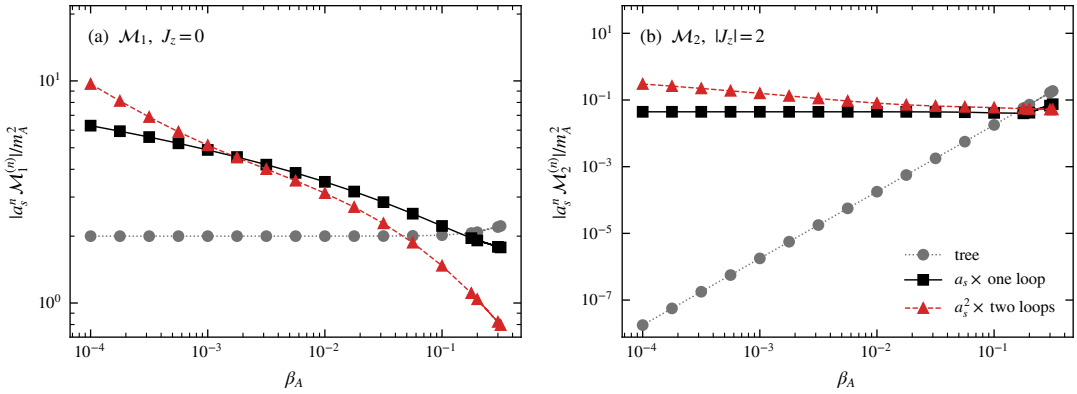



**Figure 3**. Tree-level, one-loop and two-loop terms of the Type II amplitude, $|a_s^n \mathcal{M}_i^{(n)}|/m_A^2$ with $\alpha_s = 0.118$, at $c = 1/3$, $m_A = \mu_R = 125\,\text{GeV}$, $N_c = 3$ and $n_f = 5$. Tree level: Eq. (2.12); one loop: remainder of Ref. [12] with the scale dependence of Eq. (2.16) restored; two loops: series through $\beta_A^6$. $\mathcal{M}_1$ and $\mathcal{M}_2$ are the equal and opposite helicity amplitudes, Eq. (2.10).

### 4.2 One loop

Fitting the one-loop remainders of Ref. [12] at $\beta_A = 10^{-40}$ and $10^{-50}$ with 400-digit arithmetic, for $N_c = 3$, 4 and 5, $n_f = 0$, 2 and 5, two values of $\mu_R$ and several angles, we find to 30 digits

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{M}_1^{(1)} &= m_A^2\left[7\pi N_c\,\mathcal{L} + \widehat{A}_{10}^{(1)}\right] + \mathcal{O}_{\log}(\beta_A^2), \\ \mathcal{M}_2^{(1)} &= \tfrac{1}{2}\pi N_c\, m_A^2 + \mathcal{O}_{\log}(\beta_A^2), \end{aligned} \tag{4.7}$$

with $\widehat{A}_{10}^{(1)} = -93.900 + 11.484\,i$ for $N_c = 3$, $n_f = 5$ and $\mu_R = m_A$, in the normalisation of Eq. (2.16). Evaluations at $10^{-6} \le \beta_A \le 10^{-3}$ show that the first corrections are of order $\beta_A^2 \ln \beta_A$ for $\mathcal{M}_1^{(1)}$ and $\beta_A^2$ for $\mathcal{M}_2^{(1)}$. The constant does not depend on the angle, and by Eq. (2.16), its scale dependence is $\partial \widehat{A}_{10}^{(1)}/\partial \ln \mu_R^2 = 4i\beta_0$. The coefficient of $\mathcal{L}$ and the limit of $\mathcal{M}_2^{(1)}$ depend neither on $n_f$ nor on $\mu_R$. Together with Eqs. (2.12), (4.3) and (4.4), the behaviour at threshold is summarised in Table 6. The $|J_z| = 2$ amplitude is suppressed

| | tree level | one loop | two loops |
|---|---|---|---|
| $\mathcal{M}_1$ $(J_z = 0)$ | $2im_A^2$ | $\mathcal{L}$ | $\mathcal{L}^3$ |
| $\mathcal{M}_2$ $(\lvert J_z\rvert = 2)$ | $2im_A^2\beta_A^2(1-c^2)$ | $\mathcal{L}^0$ | $\mathcal{L}^2$ |

**Table 6**. Behaviour of the Type II coefficients at threshold, $\beta_A \to 0$ at fixed angle: tree-level values, and the highest power of $\mathcal{L}$ at one and two loops.

near threshold only at tree level. According to Eq. (2.10), $\mathcal{A}_{\pm\mp}$ retains the azimuthal factor $e^{\pm 2i\phi}$ as $|\vec{p}_3| \to 0$. The loop amplitude therefore has a direction-dependent limit and is not analytic in $\vec{p}_3$ at the origin. At one loop $\mathcal{M}_2$ approaches a nonzero constant without a DPS logarithm; at two loops it also acquires the logarithm discussed in Sec. 4.4.

### 4.3 The double parton scattering singularity

**Origin of the logarithm.** The logarithm $\mathcal{L}$ in Eq. (4.7) can be understood from the one-loop Type II diagrams near $p_T = 0$, shown in Fig. 1(b). As $p_T \to 0$, all four internal gluons can be on shell simultaneously, two of them collinear to each incoming gluon. This configuration is the pinch that produces the DPS singularity of the crossed box [3]. The singular contribution can be expressed as an integral over transverse momentum of the product of the light cone wavefunctions of the two incoming gluons and the tree amplitudes of the two hard subprocesses [3]. The wavefunctions describe the splitting of each incoming parton. The hard subprocess amplitudes are evaluated with collinear on-shell incoming partons and zero transverse momentum. Thus, the splittings determine the strength of the singularity, while the hard subprocesses enter its coefficient. In the present case, the splittings are $g \to gg$ and the subprocesses are $gg \to A$ through $O_G$.

For a gluon splitting into a collinear pair, the daughter helicities add to 0 or $\pm 2$, whereas the parent helicity is $\pm 1$. The numerator of the splitting vertex therefore vanishes in the exactly collinear limit; for the allowed tree helicity configurations, it is linear in the relative transverse momentum. The corresponding light cone wavefunction behaves as the inverse of that momentum after including the propagator. The transverse momentum integral is consequently at most logarithmically singular, as in the massless quark examples of Ref. [3].

**Helicity selection and wavefunction factors.** The logarithm is present only for certain helicities of the partons in the singular configuration. For the fermion loops of Ref. [3], helicity conservation forces the four intermediate partons into $J_z = 0$; for gluon loops only conservation of $J_z$ between the incoming state and the intermediate partons remains [4, 5]. Here the effective vertices restore the restriction. The amplitude for $gg \to A$ vanishes unless the two gluons have equal helicities, and the gluons of each fusing pair move in opposite beam directions, so each pair has $J_z = 0$. A DPS logarithm is therefore possible only for incoming gluons with $J_z = 0$, which is why $\mathcal{M}_1$ has a logarithm at one loop and $\mathcal{M}_2$ does not.

For a positive-helicity gluon splitting into gluons $a$ and $b$ with longitudinal momentum fractions $\xi$ and $1-\xi$, the light cone wavefunction is, for each pair of daughter helicities, a function of $\xi$ times a phase and a power of the relative transverse momentum; with the

coupling, colour and transverse momentum factors removed, the functions of $\xi$ are

$$w_{++}(\xi) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{\xi(1-\xi)}},$$
$$w_{+-}(\xi) = \frac{\xi^2}{\sqrt{\xi(1-\xi)}},$$
$$w_{-+}(\xi) = \frac{(1-\xi)^2}{\sqrt{\xi(1-\xi)}}, \tag{4.8}$$

where the subscripts give $(h_a, h_b)$ [64, 65]. The sum of their squares, $[1+\xi^4+(1-\xi)^4]/[\xi(1-\xi)]$, is the $\xi$ dependence of the $g \to gg$ splitting function. At the DPS point, the first pseudoscalar receives a fraction $x$ of the first incoming momentum and, since the two pseudoscalars have equal masses, a fraction $1-x$ of the second [3]; in Fig. 1(b), $k = xp_1$ and $p_3 - k = (1-x)p_2$.

Since $A$ is odd under parity, which reverses all helicities, the amplitudes for $g^+g^+ \to A$ and $g^-g^- \to A$ have opposite signs [65]. For two incoming positive-helicity gluons, with the first helicity of each daughter pair referring to the gluon that goes to the first pseudoscalar, each vertex requires equal helicities, so both splittings produce the same pair: $(+,+)$, $(+,-)$ or $(-,+)$. In the mixed cases one vertex receives two negative-helicity gluons, and these contributions enter with the opposite sign. The factorised form of Ref. [3] then gives

$$\begin{aligned} F_A(x) &= w_{++}(x)w_{++}(1-x) - w_{+-}(x)w_{+-}(1-x) - w_{-+}(x)w_{-+}(1-x) \\ &= \frac{1}{x(1-x)} - 2x(1-x), \end{aligned} \tag{4.9}$$

since each mixed product equals $x(1-x)$. For a CP-even coupling to $G^2$ the two signs are equal and the mixed terms add:

$$F_S(x) = \frac{1}{x(1-x)} + 2x(1-x). \tag{4.10}$$

We call $F_A$ and $F_S$ helicity sums: they are sums over the daughter helicities of products of two wavefunction factors, overlaps of amplitudes rather than probabilities, and the relative signs in $F_A$ come from the interference of the helicity configurations. These helicity sums differ from those of the massless quark boxes for $gg \to HH$ in Ref. [3], where internal quarks of equal helicity carry complementary momentum fractions and the sum is proportional to $x(1-x)$.

**Normalisation and the forward limit.** At threshold, both pseudoscalars are at rest and $x = \frac{1}{2}$, so that $F_A(\frac{1}{2}) = \frac{7}{2}$ and $F_S(\frac{1}{2}) = \frac{9}{2}$. By Eq. (4.1), the coefficient of $\ln p_T^2$ is half the coefficient of $\mathcal{L}$. The one-loop threshold result in Eq. (4.7) therefore gives

$$\frac{7\pi N_c\, m_A^2}{2} = \frac{7}{2}\pi N_c m_A^2 = \pi N_c m_A^2 F_A\left(\frac{1}{2}\right).$$

Matching at threshold thus fixes the overall factor multiplying $F_A$ to $\pi N_c m_A^2$. This factor is obtained from the calculated amplitude; it has not been derived independently from the factorisation formula.

Having fixed this constant, the predicted dependence on $x$ can be tested away from threshold. The forward limit $c \to 1$ at fixed velocity also gives $p_T \to 0$, but the produced bosons now move along the beam. Since the test is also applied to $gg \to HH$ later, we denote the velocity and mass of the produced bosons by $\beta$ and $m$, with $\beta = \beta_A$ and $m = m_A$ for $AA$. In this limit, the longitudinal velocity of the first boson is $2x - 1$, so $x = (1+\beta)/2$.

To extract the logarithmic coefficient, we differentiate the real part of the one-loop remainder with respect to $\ln(p_T^2/m^2)$ at fixed $\beta$ and $m$, and then take the forward limit. Dividing by the normalisation fixed above defines

$$\begin{aligned} D(\beta) &\equiv \frac{1}{\pi N_c m^2} \lim_{c\to 1} \frac{\partial\, \mathrm{Re}\,\mathcal{M}_1^{(1)}}{\partial \ln p_T^2} \\ &= F_A\!\left(\frac{1+\beta}{2}\right) \qquad (gg \to AA). \end{aligned} \tag{4.11}$$

The last equality is the prediction to be tested: no further adjustment of the normalisation is made as $\beta$ is varied. We evaluated $D(\beta)$ from the exact one-loop remainders using $1 - c = 10^{-14}$ and $10^{-18}$, over $0.001 \le \beta \le 0.7$, with $N_c = 3$ and 4 and $n_f = 0$, 2 and 5. The largest relative deviation from Eq. (4.11) was $3 \times 10^{-15}$.

All logarithms in the one-loop remainder of Ref. [12] have positive arguments in the physical region, and all dilogarithms have arguments between 0 and 1. These functions are therefore real, and the real part of the remainder follows from its explicit factors of $i$. It contains no dilogarithms and simplifies to

$$\mathrm{Re}\,\mathcal{M}_1^{(1)} = \pi m^2 \left[ N_c\, F_A\!\left(\frac{1+\beta}{2}\right) \ln\frac{\beta^2(1-c^2)}{1-\beta^2 c^2} - \frac{2\beta_0}{1-\beta^2} \right], \tag{4.12}$$

which does not depend on $\mu_R$. As a numerical check, it agrees with the remainder of Ref. [12] at 1350 points with $0.001 \le \beta \le 0.99$ and $|c| \le 0.999$, for $(N_c, n_f) = (3,5)$, $(3,0)$, $(4,2)$, $(5,6)$ and $(2,1)$ and $(m, \mu_R) = (125, 125)$, $(125, 250)$ and $(300, 40)$ GeV. With 120-digit arithmetic the relative differences are below $10^{-105}$. The simplification, in exact arithmetic, and this check are part of the released package. At fixed $\beta$ and $m$, $\ln p_T^2 = \ln(1-c^2) + \mathrm{const}$, so

$$\frac{\partial\, \mathrm{Re}\,\mathcal{M}_1^{(1)}}{\partial \ln p_T^2} = \pi N_c m^2 F_A\!\left(\frac{1+\beta}{2}\right) \frac{1-\beta^2}{1-\beta^2 c^2},$$

which tends to $\pi N_c m^2 F_A\big((1+\beta)/2\big)$ as $c \to 1$. Equation (4.11) therefore holds for all $\beta$. At threshold, Eq. (4.12) gives $\mathrm{Re}\,\widehat{A}_{10}^{(1)} = -\pi(7N_c \ln 2 + 2\beta_0)$, in agreement with the value quoted after Eq. (4.7).

**Comparison with scalar pair production.** The scalar process provides a separate test of the relative signs in the helicity sum. The splittings and colour factors are unchanged, while replacing the CP-odd vertices by CP-even ones changes $F_A$ to $F_S$. We tested this prediction using the one-loop amplitudes for $gg \to HH$ in which each scalar is emitted from its own effective vertex, at the same mass $m$. We computed them with the code of Ref. [12], replacing the CP-odd vertices of $O_G$ by those of the CP-even operator $H\, G^a_{\mu\nu} G^{a\mu\nu}$ and

leaving the rest of the calculation unchanged. The code reproduces the one-loop $AA$ result of that reference to 40 digits, and the $HH$ double poles agree with Catani's formula [11].

In the conventions used here, the $HH$ tree amplitude at threshold is $-2im^2$, opposite in sign to the $AA$ amplitude. The corresponding forward coefficient satisfies

$$D(\beta) = -F_S\left(\frac{1+\beta}{2}\right) \qquad (gg \to HH)$$

to a relative accuracy of $3 \times 10^{-15}$ for $0.001 \le \beta \le 0.7$. The normalisation fixed from $AA$ therefore also reproduces the $HH$ logarithm without an additional fitted constant. In units of the respective tree amplitudes, the ratio of the scalar and pseudoscalar logarithmic coefficients at threshold is

$$\frac{F_S(\frac{1}{2})}{F_A(\frac{1}{2})} = \frac{9}{7}. \tag{4.13}$$

The opposite helicity amplitude again has no logarithm. Its extracted forward coefficient is about $3 \times 10^{-14}$ times that of $\mathcal{M}_1$. For this check, the diagram with the four-gluon term of the CP-even operator and the contact counterterm for two such insertions were not included. Neither produces a logarithm of $p_T$ as $p_T \to 0$, so neither changes the logarithmic coefficient being tested.

Figure 4(a) compares the extracted coefficients with the two helicity sums. The $AA$ points lie on the curve $F_A$ for both $(N_c, n_f) = (3, 5)$ and $(4, 2)$, so that after the normalisation of Eq. (4.11) the coefficient does not depend on $N_c$ or $n_f$. The $HH$ points (triangles), plotted with their sign reversed, lie on the curve $F_S$, which is separated from $F_A$ by

$$F_S - F_A = 4x(1-x) = 1 - \beta^2. \tag{4.14}$$

Panel (b) shows the relative deviations from the predictions; the two-loop points are discussed in Sec. 4.4.

**Colour, scale dependence and phase.** The factorisation also explains the flavour and colour dependence of the one-loop logarithm. The $O_G$ vertices couple only to gluons, so only gluon splittings enter this singular configuration and its coefficient is independent of $n_f$. The factor $N_c$ comes from the colour contraction of the two three-gluon vertices. Renormalisation and IR subtraction do not change this logarithmic coefficient: at one loop, their contributions are proportional to the tree amplitude and do not generate a logarithm of $p_T$. The coefficient is therefore independent of $\mu_R$.

Finally, the coefficient $7\pi N_c\, m_A^2$ of $\mathcal{L}$ is real, whereas $\mathcal{M}_1^{(0)} \to 2im_A^2$ at threshold. The logarithm is thus out of phase with the tree amplitude by 90°. This relative phase is consistent with the absorptive origin of the one-loop DPS singularity, which can be obtained from cuts that put internal lines on shell [3]. It explains why the one-loop DPS logarithm does not contribute to the interference with the tree amplitude, as discussed in Sec. 5.

### 4.4 Two loops

The leading logarithms of the calculated two-loop coefficient $\mathcal{M}_1$ can be written in terms of the one-loop DPS logarithm. Comparing the coefficients of Eq. (4.5) with the coefficient

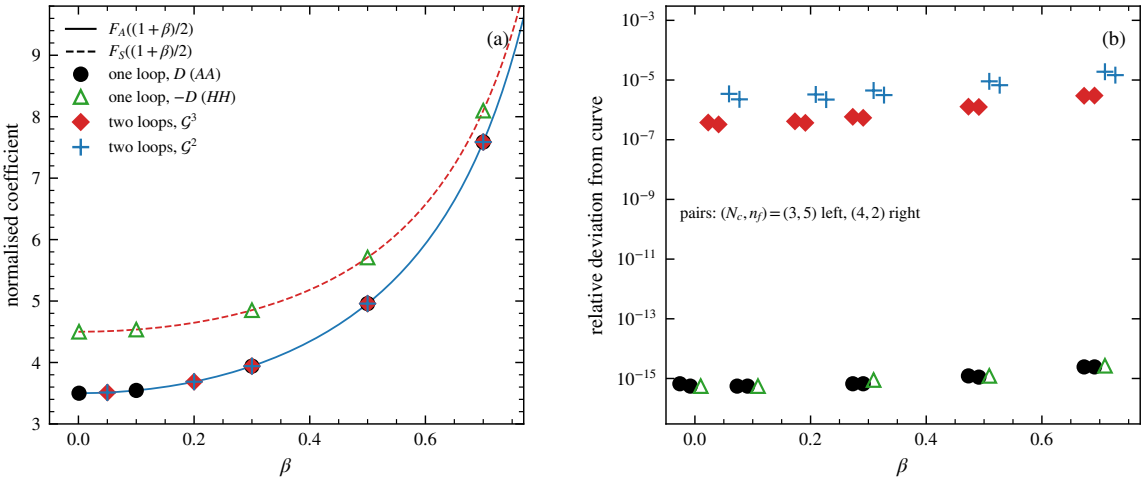



**Figure 4**. Forward coefficients of the DPS logarithms and the helicity sums $F_A$, $F_S$; each coefficient has the same symbol in both panels. (a) $(N_c, n_f) = (3, 5)$. Circles: $D(\beta)$ for $gg \to AA$, Eq. (4.11). Triangles: $-D(\beta)$ for $gg \to HH$ through two CP-even effective vertices; the sign reversal removes the relative sign of the scalar and pseudoscalar tree amplitudes at threshold. Diamonds and crosses: the real parts of the coefficients of $\mathcal{G}^3$ and $\mathcal{G}^2$ in the forward limit of the two-loop remainder of $gg \to AA$, determined from $1 - c = 10^{-7}, \ldots, 10^{-10}$ and divided by $-\frac{4}{3}N_c \cdot 2\pi N_c m^2$ and $-2\beta_0 \cdot 2\pi N_c m^2$ (Sec. 4.4). Solid and dashed curves: $F_A((1+\beta)/2)$ and $F_S((1+\beta)/2)$. The values for $(N_c, n_f) = (4, 2)$ coincide with those shown. (b) Relative deviation of each point from its curve in (a), for $(N_c, n_f) = (3, 5)$ and, for $gg \to AA$, $(4, 2)$; the symbols are displaced horizontally for legibility.

$7\pi N_c$ of Eq. (4.7) gives, for general $N_c$ and $n_f$,

$$\widehat{A}_{13}\mathcal{L}^3 + \widehat{A}_{12}\mathcal{L}^2 = 7\pi N_c\,\mathcal{L}\left[-\tfrac{4N_c}{3}\,\mathcal{L}^2 - 2\beta_0\,\mathcal{L}\right], \tag{4.15}$$

with $\beta_0$ as in Eq. (2.16). A similar relation holds in planar $\mathcal{N} = 4$ super Yang–Mills theory. The six-gluon maximally helicity violating (MHV) amplitude in planar $\mathcal{N} = 4$ super Yang–Mills theory, with two negative and four positive helicities when all momenta are outgoing, was studied in Refs. [4, 5]. Near the configuration that mimics DPS, its singular terms obey an evolution equation that fixes the leading logarithms to all orders [4, 5]. Its derivation follows the analysis of crossing Wilson lines in Ref. [66]. The ratio of the leading two-loop and one-loop terms, including their powers of the coupling, is $-(a/6)\ln^2\delta$, where $a = g^2 N_c/(8\pi^2)$ and $\delta$, which measures the approach to the singular configuration, is proportional to the squared transverse momentum at fixed values of the other kinematic variables. With $a = 2N_c a_s$ and $\ln\delta = 2\mathcal{L} + \text{const}$, the ratio becomes $-\frac{4}{3}N_c a_s \mathcal{L}^2$ at leading logarithmic order. This is the ratio of the cubic term in Eq. (4.15) to the one-loop logarithm, once the additional power of $a_s$ at two loops is included. The second term, $-2\beta_0\mathcal{L}$, has no counterpart in the $\mathcal{N} = 4$ theory; the number of quark flavours enters it only through $\beta_0$.

A corresponding $\beta_0$ coefficient appears in the NLO momentum-space kernel for $g \to gg$ splitting in unpolarised colour singlet double parton distributions [34]. There the logarithm is $L_\Delta = \ln(\mu^2/\Delta^2)$, where $\Delta$ is the transverse momentum mismatch between amplitude and conjugate amplitude, rather than the transverse momentum of a produced particle.

The LO kernel contains the LO splitting function multiplied by $L_\Delta$, and Eqs. (50) and (135) of Ref. [34] give a $\beta_0$ contribution to the coefficient of $L_\Delta^2$ equal to $\beta_0/2$ times the same splitting function, in units of $\alpha_s/2\pi$. Relative to the LO logarithmic term this is $(\alpha_s/2\pi)(\beta_0/2)L_\Delta = a_s\beta_0 L_\Delta$, which the replacement $L_\Delta \to -2\mathcal{L}$ turns into the term $-2\beta_0\mathcal{L}$ of Eq. (4.15), with the additional power of $a_s$ included. Half of this coefficient comes from the renormalisation of the coupling and half from the $\delta$-function parts of the DGLAP kernels, so that the running of the coupling alone would give $-\beta_0\mathcal{L}$. This is a comparison of coefficients, not an identification of $\Delta$ with $p_T$. The other terms of the kernel are not part of it: a term proportional to $C_A \ln[x(1-x)]$ from the plus distributions, which contributes where the two momentum fractions add up to one, and the real emission terms, which contribute where they add up to less than one.

The following tests indicate that the relation of Eq. (4.15) extends beyond threshold. In the forward limit at fixed velocity a convenient variable is $\mathcal{G} = \frac{1}{2}\ln[(m_A^4 - tu)/m_A^4] = \mathcal{L} - \ln(1-\beta_A^2)$, in which the one-loop DPS logarithm is $C_1\mathcal{G}$ and the relation reads

$$\mathcal{M}_1^{(2)} \supset C_1\Big[-\frac{4}{3}N_c\,\mathcal{G}^3 - 2\beta_0\,\mathcal{G}^2\Big], \qquad C_1 = 2\pi N_c m_A^2 F_A\Big(\frac{1+\beta_A}{2}\Big), \tag{4.16}$$

with $C_1$ from Eq. (4.11). In the threshold series, Eq. (4.16) holds exactly through $\beta_A^6$ for general $N_c$ and $n_f$; at fixed angle, the coefficient of $\mathcal{L}^3$ follows the expansion of $F_A\big((1+\beta_A)/2\big)$ order by order.

Away from threshold we evaluated the released two-loop remainder of $\mathcal{M}_1$ at $1-c = 10^{-6},\ldots,10^{-10}$ with 180-digit arithmetic. For each velocity and colour/flavour set, the point at $1-c = 10^{-10}$ was reevaluated with 220-digit arithmetic; these comparisons agree to at least 82 digits. The four points with $1-c \le 10^{-7}$ determine the four coefficients of a cubic polynomial in $\ln(1-c)$. For $0.05 \le \beta \le 0.7$ and $(N_c, n_f) = (3,5)$ and $(4,2)$, the real parts of the resulting coefficients of $\mathcal{G}^3$ and $\mathcal{G}^2$ agree with Eq. (4.16) to $4\times10^{-6}$ and $2\times10^{-5}$ (Fig. 4), and their imaginary parts are below $2\times10^{-5}$ of their magnitudes. A least-squares fit that also includes the point at $1-c = 10^{-6}$ gives deviations about four times larger, as expected from power corrections in $1-c$. Within the range tested, the two-loop leading logarithms of $\mathcal{M}_1$ in the forward limit are therefore the one-loop DPS logarithm, with its helicity sum $F_A(x)$, multiplied by the same factor at every velocity.

The $|J_z| = 2$ amplitude acquires a logarithm at two loops: the term $\widehat{A}_{22}\mathcal{L}^2$, with $\widehat{A}_{22} = (-4N_c)\cdot\frac{1}{2}\pi N_c$, is the one-loop constant multiplied by $-4N_c\,\mathcal{L}^2$. The forward-limit calculation described next indicates that the same coefficient relation persists away from threshold. In the forward limit $c \to 1$ at fixed velocity, where $p_T \to 0$ as well, we evaluated the released two-loop remainder of $\mathcal{M}_2$ at $1-c = 10^{-5}$, $10^{-6}$ and $10^{-7}$ with 140-digit arithmetic. For each velocity and colour/flavour set, the most forward fitted point, $1-c = 10^{-7}$, was reevaluated with 180-digit arithmetic; these comparisons agree to at least 51 digits. These three points determine the three coefficients of a quadratic polynomial in $\ln(1-c)$. For $0.05 \le \beta \le 0.5$ and $(N_c, n_f) = (3,5)$ and $(4,2)$, the real part of the coefficient of $\ln^2(2p_T/m)$ equals $-4N_c$ times the forward limit of $\mathcal{M}_2^{(1)}$ to $6\times10^{-5}$, although that

limit varies by a factor of 3.4 over this range. Its imaginary part, which vanishes in the proposed coefficient relation, is below $2 \times 10^{-4}$ of its magnitude. A least-squares fit that also includes the point at $1 - c = 10^{-4}$ increases the deviation to $7 \times 10^{-4}$, as expected from power corrections. Within the range tested, the one-loop amplitude and the extracted two-loop logarithm are therefore consistent with

$$a_s \mathcal{M}_2^{(1)} \bigl[1 - 4N_c a_s \ln^2(2p_T/m)\bigr], \tag{4.17}$$

with no additional velocity or flavour dependence resolved in the coefficient of the double logarithm.

The first-order expansion of $\exp[-4N_c a_s \ln^2(2p_T/m)]$, multiplied by the one-loop amplitude, reproduces Eq. (4.17) at double-logarithmic accuracy. At threshold, integrating $-4N_c\mathcal{L}^2$ with respect to $\mathcal{L}$ and multiplying by $7\pi N_c$ reproduces the cubic term of Eq. (4.15). These comparisons concern the highest logarithmic powers only. The exponent also agrees at leading order with $-\gamma_K \ln^2 \delta/8$ in Ref. [4, 5], using $\gamma_K = 4a$, $a = 2N_c a_s$ and $\ln \delta = 2\mathcal{L}+\text{const}$ at leading-logarithmic accuracy. These coefficient relations do not establish exponentiation in QCD. The $J_z$ argument of Sec. 4.3 concerns the one-loop singularity and does not forbid this logarithm. Nor can it be explained by loop corrections to the $gg \to A$ subprocess amplitudes, since conservation of angular momentum forbids $gg \to A$ for opposite gluon helicities to all orders; its dynamical origin remains open. A related effect occurs in planar $\mathcal{N} = 4$ super Yang–Mills theory. The next-to-MHV (NMHV) six-gluon amplitude, with three negative helicities, has no such singularity at one loop because of $J_z$ conservation. Logarithmic singularities starting at two loops were found in the region where this limit overlaps with multi-Regge kinematics. Contributions in which more than one particle crosses a cut were suggested as their source [4, 5].

In the forward limit the one-loop remainders agree with

$$\lim_{c\to 1} \frac{\mathcal{M}_2^{(1)}}{m^2} = \pi N_c\, W(x), \qquad W(x) = \frac{x^4 + (1-x)^4}{x(1-x)}, \qquad x = \frac{1+\beta}{2}, \tag{4.18}$$

to $2 \times 10^{-34}$ for $0.05 \le \beta \le 0.9$ and both sets of $(N_c, n_f)$; at threshold it gives $\frac{1}{2}\pi N_c$. With the factors of Eq. (4.8), $W(x) = w_{+-}(x)w_{-+}(1-x) + w_{-+}(x)w_{+-}(1-x)$. This is the sum over the two helicity pairings allowed for an opposite-helicity initial state, with equal gluon helicities at each effective vertex (Sec. 4.3). The prefactor $\pi N_c$ in Eq. (4.18) also matches that in Eq. (4.11). This structure suggests a DPS origin for the finite one-loop forward limit of $\mathcal{M}_2$, with the azimuthal phase removing the logarithm but leaving a finite term. We have not derived this term from the factorisation formula. The two helicity amplitudes provide an explicit two-loop QCD benchmark for a general description of this singular region.

Figure 3 compares the three orders. With $a_s = 0.0094$ ($\alpha_s = 0.118$), at $\beta_A = 0.1$ and $c = 1/3$, the one- and two-loop terms of $\mathcal{M}_1$ are 1.1 and 0.7 times the tree term, and the one-loop term of $\mathcal{M}_2$ is 2.3 times the tree term. The last ratio grows as $\beta_A^{-2}$ towards threshold, since the tree-level $|J_z| = 2$ amplitude vanishes there. The one-loop terms include the scale term of Eq. (2.16). Towards threshold, the loop terms of $\mathcal{M}_1$ grow with $|\mathcal{L}|$, the two-loop term as $|\mathcal{L}|^3$ and the one-loop term as $|\mathcal{L}|$, so that below $\beta_A \approx 1.7 \times 10^{-3}$ the two-loop term

exceeds the one-loop term at this angle. Because the logarithms are out of phase with the tree amplitude, the strongest of them are absent from the finite virtual correction (Sec. 5). In panel (b) the one-loop term of $\mathcal{M}_2$ tends to the constant of Eq. (4.7), while the two-loop term grows as $\mathcal{L}^2$.

## 5 Consequences for the cross section

### 5.1 Leading order

Averaging Eq. (2.10) over helicities and colours, and including a factor $\frac{1}{2}$ for identical particles, gives the LO partonic cross section of the Type II amplitude,

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}\hat{\sigma}}{\mathrm{d}c} = \frac{\beta_A\, C_G^4}{128\pi\hat{s}\,(N_c^2-1)} \left( |\mathcal{M}_1^{(0)}|^2 + |\mathcal{M}_2^{(0)}|^2 \right) \tag{5.1}$$

for $-1 < c < 1$. For $\alpha_s = 0.118$, $\cot\beta = 1$ and $m_A = 125\,\mathrm{GeV}$, we find $\hat{\sigma} = 1.29 \times 10^{-8}\,\mathrm{pb}$ at $\beta_A = 0.1$ (Fig. 5(a)). The cross section rises as $\beta_A$ above threshold and as $\hat{s}$ at large $\hat{s}$, as expected for dimension-five operators, and it is of fourth order in $a_s$ through $C_G^4$. In a 2HDM, it is a small part of the total, which is dominated by Type I (Sec. 2.5).

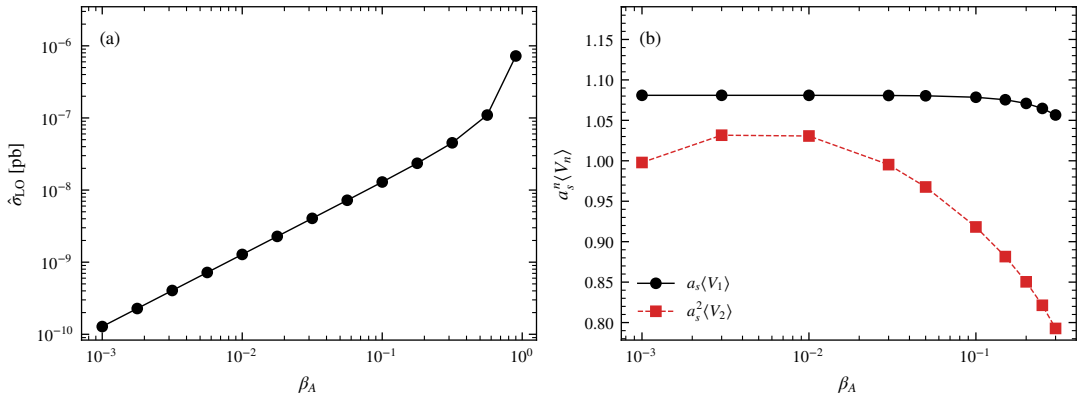



**Figure 5**. (a) Leading order partonic cross section of the Type II amplitude, Eq. (5.1), for $m_A = 125\,\mathrm{GeV}$, $\alpha_s = 0.118$ and $\cot\beta = 1$. (b) Tree-weighted angle averages $a_s\langle V_1\rangle$ and $a_s^2\langle V_2\rangle$ of the finite virtual corrections, Eq. (5.3), for $\mu_R = m_A$, $N_c = 3$ and $n_f = 5$. Real emission is not included in panel (b).

### 5.2 Finite virtual corrections

To examine the effect of the loop corrections on the Type II squared amplitude, we define two dimensionless coefficients, $V_1$ and $V_2$, relative to the tree contribution. Let $\mathcal{A}_{\mathrm{fin}}$ denote the amplitude constructed from the finite remainders of Eq. (2.14), in the normalisation of

Eq. (2.16). Using the helicity decomposition in Eq. (2.10), its square can be written as

$$\sum_{\text{hel,col}} |\mathcal{A}_{\text{fin}}|^2 = 2(N_c^2-1)\,C_G^4 \sum_i |\mathcal{M}_i^{(0)}|^2 \times \left[1 + a_s V_1 + a_s^2 V_2 + \mathcal{O}(a_s^3)\right], \text{ where}$$

$$V_1 = \frac{2\,\mathrm{Re}\sum_i \mathcal{M}_i^{(0)*}\mathcal{M}_i^{(1)}}{\sum_i |\mathcal{M}_i^{(0)}|^2},$$

$$V_2 = \frac{\sum_i \left(2\,\mathrm{Re}\left[\mathcal{M}_i^{(0)*}\mathcal{M}_i^{(2)}\right] + |\mathcal{M}_i^{(1)}|^2\right)}{\sum_i |\mathcal{M}_i^{(0)}|^2}. \tag{5.2}$$

The sums run over the two tensor coefficients, $i = 1, 2$. The coefficient $V_1$ contains the interference between the tree and one-loop amplitudes. At the next order, $V_2$ contains both the interference between the tree and two-loop amplitudes and the square of the one-loop amplitude. These coefficients refer only to the $O_G$–$O_G$ Type II contribution; they are the NLO and NNLO finite virtual terms when the Type II tree amplitude is the leading amplitude (Sec. 2.5). The real emission contributions are not included here. The quantities $V_1$ and $V_2$ therefore retain the dependence on the subtraction scheme of Eq. (2.14), which cancels only when the real emission and the counterterms for initial state collinear factorisation are added; they are not observables or $K$ factors. The coefficient of the squared logarithm derived below is not affected by the finite changes of the subtraction scheme specified below.

At fixed $\beta_A$, both coefficients depend on the scattering angle. To display their velocity dependence in Fig. 5(b), we average them over the angle with the Type II LO cross section as the weight. Since the remaining factors in Eq. (5.1) depend only on $\beta_A$ and cancel in this average, $a_s\langle V_1\rangle$ and $a_s^2\langle V_2\rangle$ are the finite virtual contributions relative to the angle-integrated tree contribution, rather than unweighted averages. The weighted average is

$$\langle V_n\rangle = \frac{\displaystyle\int_{-1}^{1} \mathrm{d}c \sum_i |\mathcal{M}_i^{(0)}|^2\, V_n}{\displaystyle\int_{-1}^{1} \mathrm{d}c \sum_i |\mathcal{M}_i^{(0)}|^2}, \qquad n = 1, 2. \tag{5.3}$$

The angular integrals are evaluated with 64-point Gauss–Legendre quadrature; with 128 points, $\langle V_1\rangle$ and $\langle V_2\rangle$ change by relative amounts smaller than $4\times10^{-52}$ and $10^{-5}$ at $\beta_A = 0.01$, 0.1 and 0.3. We evaluate the one-loop remainders without a threshold expansion and the two-loop remainders with the series through $\beta_A^6$. For $\alpha_s = 0.118$ and $\mu_R = m_A = 125\,\mathrm{GeV}$, the curves of Fig. 5(b) lie between 1.06 and 1.08 for $a_s\langle V_1\rangle$, and between 0.79 and 1.03 for $a_s^2\langle V_2\rangle$, over $10^{-3} \le \beta_A \le 0.3$. At fixed kinematics, the scale dependence of the one-loop remainder in Eq. (2.16) gives $\partial V_1/\partial \ln\mu_R^2 = 4\beta_0$.

**One-loop contribution.** The threshold behaviour of $V_1$ and $V_2$ follows from the relative phases of the tree and loop amplitudes. At fixed scattering angle, $\mathcal{M}_1^{(0)} \to 2im_A^2$, whereas $\mathcal{M}_2^{(0)}$ vanishes as $\beta_A^2$. The squared tree amplitude in the denominator of Eq. (5.2) therefore tends to $4m_A^4$, and at leading power interference with the tree amplitude selects the imaginary part of $\mathcal{M}_1^{(1)}$ or $\mathcal{M}_1^{(2)}$. With $\ell = \ln(2p_T/m_A)$, Eq. (4.1) gives $\mathcal{L} = \ell + i\pi/2 + \mathcal{O}(\beta_A^2)$,

and the one-loop result of Eq. (4.7) reads

$$\frac{\mathcal{M}_1^{(1)}}{m_A^2} = 7\pi N_c\,\ell + \frac{i\pi}{2}7\pi N_c + \widehat{A}_{10}^{(1)}.$$

The coefficient of $\ell$ is real, so the logarithm drops out of the interference with the imaginary tree amplitude. Only the imaginary constants remain:

$$V_1 \longrightarrow \frac{\pi}{2}7\pi N_c + \mathrm{Im}\,\widehat{A}_{10}^{(1)}. \tag{5.4}$$

For $N_c = 3$, $n_f = 5$ and $\mu_R = m_A$, this gives $V_1 \to 115.11$. The one-loop remainder thus contains the DPS logarithm, but the leading power finite virtual correction does not. The limit is also independent of the angle, which is why the angular average in Fig. 5(b) is nearly constant.

**Two-loop contribution.** The interference of the two-loop amplitude with the tree amplitude again selects the imaginary part of the loop remainder, but the square of the one-loop amplitude retains the real logarithm. Using Eqs. (4.3), (4.4) and (4.7), the leading power terms of Eq. (5.2) are

$$V_2\big|_{\beta_A^0} = \mathrm{Im}\left[\sum_{k=0}^{3}\widehat{A}_{1k}\mathcal{L}^k\right] + \frac{1}{4}\left|7\pi N_c\,\mathcal{L} + \widehat{A}_{10}^{(1)}\right|^2 + \frac{\pi^2 N_c^2}{16}. \tag{5.5}$$

The three terms are the interference of the two-loop amplitude with the tree amplitude, the square of $\mathcal{M}_1^{(1)}$, and the square of $\mathcal{M}_2^{(1)} \to \pi N_c m_A^2/2$. The last contributes at leading power although the corresponding tree amplitude vanishes, while the interference of $\mathcal{M}_2^{(0)}$ with $\mathcal{M}_2^{(2)}$ is suppressed by $\beta_A^2$, up to logarithms.

The coefficients $\widehat{A}_{13}$ and $\widehat{A}_{12}$ are real, and at leading power

$$\mathrm{Im}\,\mathcal{L}^3 = \frac{3\pi}{2}\ell^2 - \frac{\pi^3}{8}, \qquad \mathrm{Im}\,\mathcal{L}^2 = \pi\ell.$$

The cubic logarithm of the two-loop amplitude therefore gives only a quadratic logarithm in its interference with the tree amplitude, and $\widehat{A}_{12}\mathcal{L}^2$ only a linear one. The square of the one-loop amplitude is at most quadratic in $\ell$. The leading threshold expansion of $V_2$ therefore has the form

$$V_2 = v_0 + v_1\ell + v_2\ell^2 + \mathcal{O}_{\log}(\beta_A^2), \tag{5.6}$$

where the subscripts of $v_0$, $v_1$ and $v_2$ give the power of $\ell$, not the number of loops.

The coefficient $v_2$ receives two contributions: $\frac{3}{2}\pi\widehat{A}_{13} = -14\pi^2 N_c^2$ from the interference of the two-loop amplitude with the tree amplitude, and $\frac{1}{4}(7\pi N_c)^2 = \frac{49}{4}\pi^2 N_c^2$ from the square of the one-loop amplitude. Their sum is

$$v_2 = -14\pi^2 N_c^2 + \frac{49}{4}\pi^2 N_c^2 = -\frac{7}{4}\pi^2 N_c^2. \tag{5.7}$$

The two contributions partly cancel. At leading power, the DPS logarithm therefore first appears in the finite virtual correction in $V_2$, with highest power $\ell^2$. A fit of the numerical values of $V_2$ at $c = 1/3$ over $10^{-8} \le \beta_A \le 10^{-6}$ gives $v_2 = -155.446269$, while Eq. (5.7) gives $-155.446269$ for $N_c = 3$; the relative difference before rounding is $3 \times 10^{-11}$. For $a_s = 0.0094$, the quadratic term in the finite virtual correction is $a_s^2 v_2 \ell^2 = -0.0137\,\ell^2$.

**Remaining coefficients and numerical behaviour.** At leading power, $v_0$, $v_1$ and $v_2$ are independent of the scattering angle. The angular dependence of $V_2$ itself remains through $\ell$. Fits for $v_0$ and $v_1$ at $c = 0$, $\frac{1}{3}$ and $\frac{2}{3}$ agree within a relative spread of $5 \times 10^{-11}$. The coefficient of the linear logarithm follows from the same expansion:

$$\begin{aligned} v_1 &= \pi \widehat{A}_{12} + \operatorname{Im} \widehat{A}_{11} + \frac{7\pi N_c}{2} \operatorname{Re} \widehat{A}_{10}^{(1)} \\ &= \frac{7}{2} \pi N_c \operatorname{Re} \widehat{A}_{10}^{(1)} + 7\pi^2 N_c \beta_0 . \end{aligned}$$

With $\operatorname{Re} \widehat{A}_{10}^{(1)} = -\pi(7N_c \ln 2 + 2\beta_0)$ from Eq. (4.12), the terms proportional to $\beta_0$ cancel and $v_1 = -\frac{49}{2}\pi^2 N_c^2 \ln 2$. For $N_c = 3$ this gives $v_1 = -1508.5$, in agreement with the numerical fit to a relative difference of $1 \times 10^{-10}$. Neither $v_1$ nor $v_2$ depends on $n_f$ or $\mu_R$. At leading power, the explicit scale dependence of $V_2$ is therefore confined to $v_0$, which changes from 8118 to 15421 when $\mu_R$ is increased from $m_A$ to $2m_A$.

Although $\ell^2$ is the highest power of the logarithm, it need not give the largest contribution at the velocities considered. At $c = 1/3$, the ratio $(v_1\ell + v_2\ell^2)/V_2$ is approximately 20% at $\beta_A = 0.1$ and 30% at $\beta_A = 0.01$. The quadratic term alone contributes $-4\%$ and $-21\%$ of the total $V_2$, respectively. Since $\ell < 0$ in this region and both $v_1$ and $v_2$ are negative, the linear term is positive and the quadratic term is negative. This competition also explains the shape of the correction as a function of velocity. The leading power expression has a maximum at

$$\ell_{\max} = -\frac{v_1}{2v_2} = -7 \ln 2 = -4.85,$$

that is, $p_T = m_A/256$. At $c = 1/3$, this corresponds to $\beta_A \simeq 0.0041$. For larger $\beta_A$, $\ell$ increases and the leading power value of $V_2$ decreases. The same balance between the linear and quadratic terms explains the turnover of the angular average $a_s^2\langle V_2 \rangle$ in Fig. 5(b). At $c = 1/3$ and $\beta_A = 0.1$, including the terms beyond leading power changes $V_2$ by only 0.3%.

**DPS interpretation and subtraction dependence.** The two contributions to $v_2$ also differ in their relation to the DPS configuration. In the square of the one-loop amplitude, the DPS region occurs in both the amplitude and its complex conjugate, that is, on both sides of the final state cut. This is the configuration associated with perturbative splittings in both protons that overlaps with DPS and requires a subtraction to avoid double counting [41, 48]. In the interference with the tree amplitude, the DPS region occurs only on the loop side of the cut. Both contributions enter the finite virtual coefficient $V_2$ defined in Eq. (5.2); the logarithmic term in its one-loop square alone would therefore not give the complete coefficient $v_2$.

Although $V_2$ depends on the IR subtraction convention, $v_2$ is unchanged by finite scheme changes that multiply lower order amplitudes by angle independent functions regular at the pair threshold. The tree amplitude has no logarithm, and the one-loop remainder contains at most one power of $\ell$. Such changes can therefore affect the constant and linear terms in $V_2$, but not the coefficient of $\ell^2$.

Finally, with the Wilson coefficient counting specified in Sec. 2.5, the one-loop $O_G$–$O_J$ amplitude contributes at the same order as the two-loop $O_G$–$O_G$ amplitude. Its coefficient

$C_J$ depends on $m_t$ in the heavy top theory [12]. The mixed amplitude is proportional to the tree amplitude by Eq. (2.17). After including its Wilson coefficient and matching the normalisation, its interference with the tree amplitude gives a kinematically constant shift to $V_2$. It changes $v_0$, but not $v_1$ or $v_2$, and is not included in the results above.

### 5.3 Use in higher order calculations

For the two-body final state, $m_{AA} = \sqrt{\hat{s}} = 2m_A/\sqrt{1-\beta_A^2}$. The range $\beta_A \leq 0.2$ therefore covers pair invariant masses up to 2.06% above threshold; for $m_A = 125\,\text{GeV}$, this is $m_{AA} \leq 255.2\,\text{GeV}$. The point $\beta_A = 0.3$ lies 4.83% above threshold. We recommend the series through $\beta_A^6$ for $0 < \beta_A \leq 0.2$ at the angles tested in Tables 2 and 4. At $\beta_A = 0.3$, the largest relative error of the complete coefficients on the validation grid is $1.94 \times 10^{-3}$. These checks do not establish a uniform accuracy bound as $c \to \pm 1$, where the logarithms diverge. The series retain the complex values of both tensor coefficients, so they can be used in interference with other amplitudes, provided these are combined with the same normalisation, Wilson coefficient conventions, tensor basis and infrared subtraction scheme.

One application is the hard function of a threshold resummed or soft-virtual prediction for the pair invariant mass distribution. There, threshold refers to the limit of little energy available for additional radiation at fixed $m_{AA}$, not to $\beta_A \to 0$ [27, 28, 30]. At leading power in the soft limit, the soft and collinear factors are universal for gluon fusion into a colour singlet, and the process dependence enters through the finite virtual contributions at each $m_{AA}$ [29, 31]; the series supply the two-loop Type II input near $m_{AA} = 2m_A$. When the Type II tree amplitude is the leading amplitude, the required combinations are those of Eq. (5.2), and integrated over the angle at fixed $m_{AA}$ they give the averages of Eq. (5.3); Ref. [30] gives the corresponding construction for Higgs pairs.

In a 2HDM, these remainders first contribute at N$^3$LO through interference with the leading Type I amplitude (Sec. 2.5). This interference must be formed before angular integration, so the averages in Eq. (5.3) cannot be used directly. All remaining amplitudes at this order are also required, including any mixed $O_G$–$O_J$ contribution. For Higgs pairs, the NNLO virtual corrections likewise involve diagrams with two effective vertices only at tree level and one loop [67]. Their two-loop terms are an ingredient of N$^3$LO [17].

## 6 Conclusions

We have expanded the two-loop Type II finite remainders for $gg \to AA$ with two $O_G$ insertions about the pair production threshold through $\beta_A^6$ at fixed scattering angle. After reducing the endpoint constants to a basis of eight transcendental constants with numerically identified relations, all inverse powers of $\beta_A$ and odd powers through $\beta_A^5$ cancel identically. Every coefficient is even in $\cos\theta$. At the tested points with $0 < \beta_A \leq 0.2$, including points close to the beam axis ($|c| \leq 0.999$), the series reproduce the two complete remainders with maximum relative errors of $3.23 \times 10^{-6}$ and $6.77 \times 10^{-5}$, respectively. The series files are a factor of 5061 smaller than those of Ref. [12]. After conversion using Eq. (2.16), the remainders pass the renormalisation group checks of Eqs. (B.1) and (B.3) (App. B).

At leading power the angular dependence enters only through the logarithm of the transverse momentum, which we identified with the DPS singularity of Ref. [3]. The $g \to gg$ wavefunction factors and the relative sign of the CP-odd subprocess amplitudes fix the momentum fraction dependence of its coefficient; with the overall constant fixed at threshold, this reproduces the one-loop coefficient in the forward limit exactly, as Eq. (4.12) shows, and a one-loop $gg \to HH$ calculation confirms the CP-even helicity sum with the same constant. At two loops the $J_z = 0$ and $|J_z| = 2$ remainders develop leading logarithms $\mathcal{L}^3$ and $\mathcal{L}^2$, respectively. The equal-helicity leading-logarithmic ratio agrees with the corresponding result in planar $\mathcal{N} = 4$ super Yang–Mills theory [4, 5], and the comparison with the NLO $g \to gg$ splitting kernel for double parton distributions concerns its $\beta_0$ coefficient [34]. In the forward variable $\mathcal{G}$, fits support Eq. (4.16) at the tested velocities in $0.05 \leq \beta_A \leq 0.7$. For the opposite-helicity remainder, fits at the tested velocities in $0.05 \leq \beta_A \leq 0.5$ support a real double-logarithmic coefficient equal to $-4N_c$ times the one-loop forward remainder of Eq. (4.18). At leading power, the one-loop DPS logarithm drops out of the tree interference because of their relative phase. At the next order, the cubic logarithm of the two-loop remainder gives a quadratic logarithm in this interference. Combining the interference with the one-loop square gives $V_2 \supset -\frac{7}{4}\pi^2 N_c^2 \ln^2(2p_T/m_A)$.

Several questions remain open: the derivation of the overall factor $\pi N_c m^2$ from the factorisation formula with the effective vertices, the mechanism that produces the $|J_z| = 2$ double logarithm, and whether the observed factor exponentiates. A general treatment of this singular region would have to reproduce the different logarithmic powers of the two amplitudes, their colour and flavour dependence and the reduced singularity of the finite virtual correction; the present results provide explicit two-loop QCD benchmarks for it, and the known two-loop $gg \to HH$ amplitudes with two effective vertices [17] permit the same comparison for the scalar case.

The series provide the two-loop Type II input to the hard function for the pair invariant mass distribution near $m_{AA} = 2m_A$, at NNLO for a pseudoscalar coupled to gluons only through $G\tilde{G}$ and at N$^3$LO in a 2HDM (Sec. 5.3).

## Data Availability

The threshold series, construction files, construction and validation code, outputs of the original runs, validation records, code for numerical evaluation, endpoint constant reductions, tree-level projections, the one-loop $gg \to HH$ coefficients used in Sec. 4.3 and the scripts that reproduce all tables and figures form one package, in which the one-loop $gg \to HH$ coefficients enter as computed values. The updated version is provided as ancillary files with the arXiv version of this article and as Supplemental Material [49]. It is maintained at `https://github.com/abhattacharya1992/ggAA-threshold` and archived at Zenodo, doi:10.5281/zenodo.23597489. The unexpanded finite remainders of Ref. [12] are downloaded from arXiv by the package and checked against their checksums. The code used to generate the one-loop $gg \to HH$ coefficients is not included and is available from the author on request.

| $[p,q,a,w]$ | reduction |
|---|---|
| $[1,2,-1,1]$ | $-\frac{\pi^2\ln 2}{6}+\frac{5\zeta_3}{8}$ |
| $[1,2,1/2,1/2]$ | $-\frac{\zeta_3}{4}-\frac{\ln^3 2}{6}+\frac{\pi^2\ln 2}{12}$ |
| $[1,2,1/2,1]$ | $-\zeta_3+\frac{\pi^2\ln 2}{4}$ |
| $[2,1,-1,-1]$ | $\frac{\zeta_3}{8}$ |
| $[2,1,-1,1]$ | $-\frac{13\zeta_3}{8}+\frac{\pi^2\ln 2}{4}$ |
| $[2,1,1,-1]$ | $-\frac{\pi^2\ln 2}{4}+\zeta_3$ |
| $[2,1,1,1/2]$ | $-\frac{5\zeta_3}{8}+\frac{\pi^2\ln 2}{6}$ |
| $[2,1,1/2,1/2]$ | $-\frac{\ln^3 2}{6}+\frac{\zeta_3}{8}$ |
| $[2,1,1/2,1]$ | $-\frac{\pi^2\ln 2}{4}+\frac{13\zeta_3}{8}$ |
| $[2,2,1,-1]$ | $-\frac{71\pi^4}{1440}-\frac{\pi^2\ln^2 2}{6}+\frac{\ln^4 2}{6}+4\,\mathrm{Li}_4(\frac{1}{2})+\frac{7\ln 2\zeta_3}{2}$ |
| $[2,2,1,1/2]$ | $-\mathrm{Li}_4(\frac{1}{2})-\frac{\ln 2\zeta_3}{4}-\frac{\pi^2\ln^2 2}{24}-\frac{\ln^4 2}{24}+\frac{19\pi^4}{1440}$ |
| $[2,2,1/2,1/2]$ | $-\frac{\pi^2\ln^2 2}{24}+\frac{\ln^4 2}{24}+\frac{\pi^4}{1440}+\frac{\ln 2\zeta_3}{4}$ |
| $[2,2,1/2,1]$ | $-3\,\mathrm{Li}_4(\frac{1}{2})-\frac{\pi^2\ln^2 2}{8}-\frac{\ln^4 2}{8}+\frac{7\pi^4}{288}$ |

**Table 7**. Reductions of the endpoint constants of Eq. (A.1), found with PSLQ at 110 digits; the largest residual is $4\times10^{-107}$.


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## A Endpoint constants

The boundary values of the expansion contain the constants

$$\mathrm{MB}[p,q,a,w]=\frac{a}{(p-1)!}\int_0^1 \mathrm{d}t\,\frac{[-\ln t]^{p-1}}{1-at}\,\mathrm{Li}_q(wt), \tag{A.1}$$

with $\mathrm{Li}_1(z)=-\ln(1-z)$. Here $p$ and $q$ are positive integers, $p-1$ being the power of the logarithm and $q$ the weight of the polylogarithm, so $\mathrm{MB}[p,q,a,w]$ has weight $p+q$; the constants that occur have $p,q\in\{1,2\}$, and $a$ and $w$ take the values $-1$, $\frac{1}{2}$ and 1. Besides the elementary values $\mathrm{MB}[2,2,1,1]=\pi^4/120$ and $\mathrm{MB}[2,1,1,1]=\zeta_3$, thirteen distinct constants occur. They were evaluated by quadrature at high precision, independently of the amplitude data, and reduced to the basis of Eq. (3.3) with the PSLQ algorithm [61] at 110 digits. Table 7 lists the results; the largest residual is $4\times10^{-107}$; the same relations were obtained in Mathematica.

## B Normalisation of the released remainders

Six checks establish the normalisation in Eq. (2.16), using the tree amplitudes, finite remainders and Mathematica code of the original calculation [12].

*Tree level.* The projections of the two tree diagrams reproduce Eq. (2.12) after removing a colour factor $N_c^2-1$ present only in the $T_1$ file. Evaluating the diagrams directly with the vertex $iC_G\varepsilon_{\mu\alpha\rho\beta}k_1^\mu k_2^\rho\delta^{ab}$, obtained from Eq. (1.1), gives $|\mathcal{A}_{\pm\pm}| = C_G^2|\mathcal{M}_1^{(0)}|$ and $|\mathcal{A}_{\pm\mp}| = C_G^2|\mathcal{M}_2^{(0)}|$ to 14 digits.

*Tree and one loop.* At threshold, the ratio of the $n_f$ coefficient in $\mathcal{M}_i^{(1)}$ to $\mathcal{M}_i^{(0)}$ is the same for $i=1,2$. Its imaginary part equals $-2\pi/3$ to 15 digits at every tested point. The one-loop diagrams proportional to $n_f$ have no cut in the $\hat{s}$ channel. This imaginary part therefore comes from the $n_f$ part of $\beta_0\ln(-\hat{s}/\mu_R^2)$ in the subtraction term $2I^{(1)}\mathcal{M}^{(0)}$ of Eq. (2.14). The check fixes the tree normalisation and phase relative to the one-loop remainders.

*Scale dependence at one loop.* At fixed $\beta_A$ and $c$, dimensional analysis requires $\mathcal{M}_i^{(1)}/m_A^2$ to depend on $m_A$ and $\mu_R$ only through their ratio. The released remainders are instead independent of $\mu_R$ because their eight $\ln\mu_R^2$ terms cancel. Under $(m_A,\mu_R)\to(\lambda m_A,\lambda\mu_R)$, $\mathcal{M}_{i,\mathrm{publ}}^{(1)}/m_A^2$ changes by $-2\beta_0\ln\lambda^2\,\mathcal{M}_i^{(0)}/m_A^2$, to a relative accuracy of $7\times10^{-56}$. The original calculation renormalises the amplitude with $Z_{GG}^2$, where $Z_{GG}=Z_{a_s}$ and $C_G\propto a_s$. Together with the scale factor $(-\hat{s}/\mu_R^2)^{\epsilon/2}$ in the one-loop subtraction operator of Eq. (2.14), renormalisation group invariance of Eq. (2.13) requires

$$\frac{\partial\mathcal{M}^{(1)}}{\partial\ln\mu_R^2} = 2\beta_0\,\mathcal{M}^{(0)}. \tag{B.1}$$

The first line of Eq. (2.16) restores this dependence. The corrected ratios $\mathcal{M}_i^{(1)}/m_A^2$ are invariant under the common rescaling to a relative accuracy of $6\times10^{-57}$.

*Scale dependence at two loops.* The subtraction operator $I^{(2)}$ implemented in the original code differs from Eqs. (3.3) and (3.5) of Ref. [12] by omitting the factor $(-\hat{s}/\mu_R^2)^\epsilon$ multiplying

$$H_g^{(2)} = \tfrac{1}{2}\Big[C_A^2\big(-\tfrac{5}{12}-\tfrac{11}{24}\zeta_2-\tfrac{1}{2}\zeta_3\big)+C_An_f\big(\tfrac{29}{27}+\tfrac{\zeta_2}{12}\big)-\tfrac{1}{2}C_Fn_f-\tfrac{5}{27}n_f^2\Big]. \tag{B.2}$$

With this convention, the scale dependence is

$$\frac{\partial\mathcal{M}^{(2)}}{\partial\ln\mu_R^2} = 3\beta_0\,\mathcal{M}^{(1)}+\big(2\beta_1-8H_g^{(2)}-12C_Fn_f\big)\mathcal{M}^{(0)}, \tag{B.3}$$

where $\beta_1=\frac{34}{3}C_A^2-2C_Fn_f-\frac{10}{3}C_An_f$. The term $-12C_Fn_f\mathcal{M}^{(0)}$ comes from the counterterm of the $O_G$–$O_J$ amplitude, Eq. (2.17), in the renormalisation of Ref. [12].

We fitted $\partial\mathcal{M}^{(2)}/\partial\ln\mu_R^2 = a\,\beta_0\mathcal{M}^{(1)}+b\,\mathcal{M}^{(0)}$ to the series at two kinematic points, for $(N_c,n_f,m_A)=(3,0,300\,\mathrm{GeV})$, $(3,5,125\,\mathrm{GeV})$ and $(4,2,150\,\mathrm{GeV})$. With both conversions in Eq. (2.16), the fit gives $a=3$ to $2\times10^{-7}$ and agreement for $b$ with Eq. (B.3) to $2\times10^{-5}$, the accuracy of the series at these velocities. The second derivative agrees with $6\beta_0^2\mathcal{M}^{(0)}$, as implied by Eqs. (B.1) and (B.3), to $1\times10^{-8}$. Without division by 64, the fit gives $a=$

192. Without the one-loop scale term, $b$ differs from Eq. (B.3) by $6\beta_0^2 \ln(m_A^2/\mathrm{GeV}^2)$. The agreement also fixes the reference scale of the released one-loop remainders at $\mu_R = 1$ GeV.

*Origin of the factor 64.* The original code multiplies the $O_G$–$O_G$ amplitude by $64 = 8^2$ during two-loop renormalisation, including the tree and one-loop amplitudes used in IR subtraction. The one-loop step does not apply this factor. The pole cancellation of Ref. [12] is unaffected because all terms of the two-loop subtraction carry the same factor. The accompanying code and data use the normalisation of Eq. (2.16).

*The original output.* The Mathematica output of the original calculation confirms both conversions. Its one-loop remainders, normalised to the tree amplitude, have the scale dependence of Eq. (B.1) and agree with the first line of Eq. (2.16) to $5 \times 10^{-56}$. The released one-loop files coincide with these outputs at $\mu_R = 1$ GeV.

An earlier two-loop renormalisation run, without the factor 64 and with the $O_J$ contribution switched off, was evaluated at $v = 1/11$, $z = 3/11$. Multiplying this result by 64 and the tree amplitude, then adding the $O_G$–$O_J$ counterterm, reproduces the real part of the released $\mathcal{M}^{(2)}_{1,\mathrm{publ}}$ remainder to $5 \times 10^{-31}$. The imaginary parts differ by $32C_F$ times the one-loop $O_G$–$O_J$ amplitude, which is proportional to the tree amplitude. This run is not an alternative result. Its renormalisation constant exceeds $Z^2_{GG} = Z^2_{a_s}$ by a $2\beta_1 a_s^2/\epsilon$ pole, and the $O_G$–$O_J$ counterterm is absent. Its single poles therefore do not cancel with the IR subtraction of the released version. In the released version, cancellation of the $C_F n_f$ single pole fixes the normalisation of this counterterm. A June 2019 record of the original calculation requires the same factor in both projections at seven kinematic points. The files and a script reproducing these comparisons are provided with this article.

## C Flavour decomposition

The decomposition of Eq. (2.15) separates the part of each remainder that is independent of $n_f$ from the parts proportional to $n_f$ and $n_f^2$. To see whether these parts add or cancel in the complete remainder, we evaluate it at $n_f = 5$:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{M}^{(2)}_i(5) &= \mathcal{M}^{(2)}_{i,0} + 5\,\mathcal{M}^{(2)}_{i,1} + 5^2\,\mathcal{M}^{(2)}_{i,2} \\ &\equiv a_0 + a_1 + a_2, \qquad i = 1, 2. \end{aligned} \tag{C.1}$$

The index $i$ is suppressed in $a_r$. The factors 5 and $5^2$ are included in $a_1$ and $a_2$, so these are the three terms of the complete remainder rather than the flavour coefficients themselves.

Figure 6 shows $|a_r|/|\mathcal{M}^{(2)}_i(5)|$ at $c = 1/3$, $N_c = 3$ and $m_A = \mu_R = 125\,\mathrm{GeV}$. Since the terms are complex, the ratios need not add to unity; a value above unity means that a term is larger in magnitude than the full remainder and is partly cancelled by the others. The $n_f$ independent term is the largest in both coefficients over the plotted range. The term linear in $n_f$ is not small and, for $\mathcal{M}_1$, partly cancels the $n_f$-independent term. The cancellation can be quantified by

$$1 - \frac{|a_0 + a_1 + a_2|}{|a_0| + |a_1| + |a_2|},$$

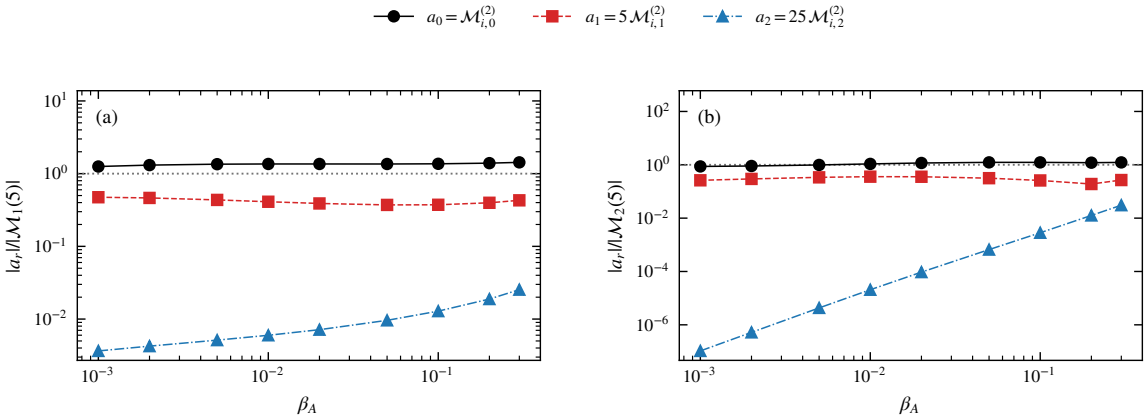



**Figure 6**. Magnitudes of the three terms of Eq. (C.1), divided by the magnitude of the complete coefficient: (a) $\mathcal{M}_1$, (b) $\mathcal{M}_2$, for $c = 1/3$, $m_A = \mu_R = 125\,\text{GeV}$ and $N_c = 3$. The horizontal line marks unity.

which is zero for terms of equal phase and one for complete cancellation. For $\mathcal{M}_1$ it lies between 42.2% and 46.9% over the plotted range: the complete remainder is roughly half the sum of the magnitudes of its terms. This refers to the remainder, not the cross section. The flavour terms are therefore not a small correction, and a remainder evaluated at one value of $n_f$ cannot be rescaled to another. The relative sign is visible in the leading power coefficients: $\widehat{A}_{12}$ depends on $n_f$ only through $\beta_0 = (11N_c - 2n_f)/3$, and $\widehat{A}_{11}$ and $\widehat{A}_{21}$ contain $N_c a_\text{A} - n_f a_\text{F}$ and $4N_c - n_f$ [Eqs. (4.5) and (4.6)], so the quark terms enter with the opposite sign to the gluon terms, as in the running of the coupling. How much they cancel in the complete remainder also depends on their phases and on the powers of $\mathcal{L}$ they multiply. The constants $\widehat{A}_{10}$ and $\widehat{A}_{20}$ are given only numerically (Table 5), and no sign pattern is stated for them or for the power corrections; their flavour parts are included in $a_r$.

Finally, the $n_f^2$ term of $\mathcal{M}_2$ starts at $\beta_A^2(1 - c^2)$ (Eq. (3.7)). At leading power, this term is proportional to the tree amplitude, with the same factor in both tensor structures (Sec. 3.2), so in $\mathcal{M}_2$, it shares the centrifugal suppression of the $|J_z| = 2$ tree amplitude. This is why its relative contribution in panel (b) becomes small near threshold.

## D Evaluation time and released data

The series through $\beta_A^6$ occupy 40 kB, against 204 MB for the published two-loop files, a factor of 5061. The evaluation time was measured before the reduction of Sec. 3.2, with the unexpanded expressions and the series in the forms used for the comparison of Sec. 3.3, at $\beta_A = 1/10$, $1/5$ and $3/10$, $c = 0$, $m_A = \mu_R = 125\,\text{GeV}$ and $N_c = 3$, with 80-digit working precision. On a first evaluation the series is 3.84–4.83 times faster. For repeated evaluations at the same point it is 18.99–19.22 times faster, with median 19.18; this does not correspond to a scan over new points. The two timed representations occupy 0.61 MiB and 42.77 MiB on disk, a factor of 70.4. Table 8 gives the individual measurements. The measurements used Wolfram Language 13.2.0 for Linux x86 under Ubuntu 24.04.2 LTS on an AMD Ryzen 9 7950X processor with 124.9 GiB of memory.

| | first call [s] | | | repeated [s] | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| $\beta_A$ | exact | series | ratio | exact | series | ratio |
| 1/10 | 56.04 | 11.61 | 4.83 | 0.3422 | 0.0178 | 19.18 |
| 1/5 | 45.68 | 11.64 | 3.92 | 0.3403 | 0.0179 | 18.99 |
| 3/10 | 44.64 | 11.64 | 3.84 | 0.3485 | 0.0181 | 19.22 |

**Table 8**. Evaluation time for the two complete Type II coefficients at the benchmark parameters, $c = 0$ and 80-digit working precision, for the unexpanded remainders (exact) and the series. First calls start with empty caches; repeated times are medians of seven evaluations at the same point. Starting the kernel and loading the files are excluded.

The construction files are organised by flavour coefficient and power of $\beta_A$, from $\beta_A^{-4}$ through $\beta_A^6$. The series are supplied in Wolfram Language form, with numerical evaluation code in Python and Wolfram Language. The package contains 1080 validation records and the forward angle data. The construction and validation code is written in Wolfram Language, C++ and Python. The construction files and validation records are checked against the outputs of the original runs, and a script repeats the construction from the published expressions. Each table, figure and number in this paper is generated by a single command, from these data or, for Fig. 1, from its diagram source. This includes the check of the helicity sums in Fig. 4, which starts from the supplied $gg \to HH$ coefficients, the logarithms of Sec. 5 and the normalisation checks of App. B. A test suite checks the numerical evaluation code against the validation records. Only the construction of the series from the unexpanded expressions requires Mathematica. The series are intended for $\beta_A \leq 0.2$ at the angles tested (Sec. 5.3). Outside this range, use the unexpanded remainders.

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